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and Conservation

From Dust to Dust:

Clay figurines as a conduit for ancestral veneration at the Pitted Ware culture settlement of Tråsättra

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Abstract

Hed, M. 2026. *From Dust to Dust - Clay figurines as a conduit for ancestral veneration at the Pitted Ware culture settlement of Tråsättra.*

(English) The anthropomorphic clay figurines of the Pitted Ware culture add a new dimension to ancestral veneration among North European Neolithic hunter-gatherers. Their design suggests body wrappings and plastered death masks as part of mortuary practices. Their fragmentation, along with the presence of red ochre in relation to figurines, graves, and other site features, introduces an additional ritual dimension. The analysis further suggests an early conceptualization of alloforms: that all in this cosmos is created from the same soil and returns to it upon death, making humans and figurines indivisible. Using ritual theory and ethnographic analogy, this thesis examines mortuary practices and religious systems of similar cultures to understand what the figurines depict and their role in the social structure of the Pitted Ware community of Tråsättra.
Key words: *Pitted Ware culture, Neolithic, figurines, Tråsättra, ritual, fragmentation, alloforms, cosmology, red ochre, wrapped bodies, death masks*

Hed, M. 2026. *Av Jord är du Kommen - Lerfiguriner som förmedlare av förfädersdyrkan inom den gropkeramisk kulturen vid Tråsättra.*

(Swedish/Svenska) De antropomorfa lerfigurinerna från den gropkeramiska kulturen tillför en ny dimension till förfädersdyrkan hos nordeuropeiska neolitiska jägar-samlare. Deras utformning antyder svepta kroppar och dödsmasker som del av begravningspraktiker. Deras fragmentering, samt förekomsten av rödockra i relation till figuriner, gravar och andra lämningar, introducerar ytterligare en rituell dimension. Analysen föreslår även en tidig konceptualisering av alloformer: att allt i kosmos är skapat av samma jord och återvänder till den vid döden, vilket gör människor och figuriner odelbara. Med hjälp av ritualteori och etnografisk analogi undersöker uppsatsen begravningspraktiker och trosföreställningar i liknande kulturer, för att förstå vad figurinerna representerar och vilken roll de spelade i den gropkeramiska sociala strukturen vid Tråsättra.
Nyckelord: *Gropkeramisk kultur, Neolitikum, figuriner, Tråsättra, ritual, fragmentering, alloformer, kosmologi, rödockra, svepta kroppar, dödsmasker*

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Front page picture: Figurine head of the western type from the Geta settlement on Åland, Finland. Photo by: Karppanen, Marjo. Retrieved 2026/03/27.

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Preface

When I first started pondering regarding what to write my master's thesis on, the general area was easy to decide. I wanted to write about the Neolithic, and the belief system of the Pitted Ware culture - just as I did for my Bachelor's. But it was not until my visit to Arkeologerna SHM's office in Uppsala, where I first encountered the figurines of Tråsättra that I decided. *This* is what I will study. What are they? What do they represent and why were they broken? Why was there not a *single one* intact in or around the settlement? As my research continued, and I discovered that the same ritual patterns existed in similar traditions related to figurines and dead bodies, not just around the Baltic, but in multiple cultures over space and time it became all the more clear that the figurines of Tråsättra existed for a reason. Despite the biblical connotations of the name of this thesis, the contents are not in any manner Christian; I have simply borrowed the formulation. It is inspired by the theory suggesting that according to hunter-gatherer cosmology, everything on this Earth is made from the same fundamental elements. Being created from the soil, and returning to it when one dies - "From Dust to Dust". These two years of researching the Neolithic world has opened my eyes even further on how we - humans - have always found ways to connect with each other, across time, space and existential planes. I have also found myself feeling nostalgic, longing for my return to a reality that I have never existed in. In studying these communities, spending hour after hour reading articles, academic papers, excavation reports, and trying to simply understand what purpose these figurines might have had, I have developed an odd feeling of intimacy towards the material, and the humans that provided it. Who were they and what went through their minds? What did they feel, and why did they act in this manner? Will I, or anyone, ever really know or understand their true intentions? This curiosity and nostalgic longing have fueled the writing process and made me want to reach deeper and to continue trying to decipher the complex world of the Baltic hunter-gatherers.

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1. Introduction

This thesis will argue and discuss the matter of burnt clay figurines of the Baltic being representative of ancestors, with a certain focus towards the Pitted Ware culture (3200–2300 BC) settlement of Tråsättra in the Mälardalen archipelago of Sweden. Throughout this thesis, I will refer to the "Baltic type" figurine, which encompasses the eastern and older type (3900–3000 BC) typically associated with the Typical Comb Ware culture and Porous Ware culture. And, the western and younger type (3300–2500 BC), typically associated with late Comb Ceramic culture and the Pitted Ware culture. The western type is the main type of this thesis, more on the types under chapter 2.2. Several additional settlements, figurines, burial grounds etc., will be included in the analysis to widen the perspective and strengthen the arguments. When analyzing prehistory it is of utmost importance to be aware of the fact that communities operated under different circumstances than we do today. What might seem strange and unfamiliar for our modern perception of the world might have been normal in the past and important to social structure. What is more, ritualized actions that can be traced over time and space require a collective agreement that this tradition is worth keeping. Actions have purpose, and it is through ritualized actions that we might find it. Death is liminal and transgressional - a phase where the individual becomes a vessel for emotions that some may argue are contradicting, love, anger, grief, devotion, lust, sorrow, longing, etc. The body then simultaneously represents a fluid personhood, being a subject and an object at the same time - fully representing death as well as encompassing the memories and emotions tied to the individual. Humans have always applied certain ceremonies and rituals to commemorate the deceased. Just as today and all throughout history, it is difficult to come to terms with losing someone; humans need rituals to make sense of their new situation. For the Pitted Ware culture, such rituals included reconnecting to older generations through reburial in older settlement layers, ritual dismemberment and collective graves. And, it is suggested in this thesis that the Pitted Ware culture of Scandinavia also adopted certain burial practices from the sphere of the Comb Ceramic culture - such as wrapped burials and plastered clay masks, explored through the figurines of this thesis. Wrapping the dead in animal skin morphs the human with the sacred animal, making them indivisible upon death as well as transferring the power of the animal to the ancestor. Transcending into this new social identity as an ancestor as well as protector, they can now affect the settlement and the community in different manners from when they were alive. The same basic function can be applied to the plastered death masks, acting as a door between this existence and the next, subsequently "closing" the former life and "opening" the next. The clay anthropomorphic and zoomorphic figurines of Tråsättra in Österåker municipality in the Swedish archipelago provides archaeology with a unique opportunity to study the dualism between animate and inanimate material. It further reveals how ancestral veneration manifested during the North European Neolithic, and allows archaeology to more steadily grasp the bigger picture of how mortuary practices might present itself in the material record. The ritual practice of fragmentation and dismemberment is a phenomenon that can be observed across the entire Baltic region. In turn, this might relate to a larger cosmological idea of how every living being, as well as the soil, trees, water, plants, the wind, etc., is part of the *alloform* of creation. That is, everything is created from the same basic elements and will upon death return to the soil and once again become a part of the cosmos. In this sense, everything is connected, and everything on this Earth needs to be respected - because we are all made from the same earthly components. "From Dust to Dust". Therefore, as this thesis will propose, the

humans that shaped clay into the corporal bodies of the figurines, did not see these as material and inanimate objects - but as equals.

1.1 Aim

The Pitted Ware culture (3200–2300 BC), represents an enigmatic and puzzling ideology that even the most established scholars within the discipline cannot fully decipher. The figurines, and their supposed intentional fragmentation (see Cederhvarf 1912; Stenbäck 2003; Björck 2020; Lindström 2024), is a well-reviewed topic. However, the matter of the intentional destruction of figurines as an established mechanism of ritualistic practice in relation to ancestral worship and mortuary practices is a neglected discourse that demands to be discussed. The aim of this thesis is to aid in further interpretation of how the *life-cycle* of these figurines are intertwined with the life and death of the humans that created them. After all, Pitted Ware culture settlements already present clues to ancestral worship through the scattering of bones and ceramic vessels, missing skulls and upper body elements, burying kin in old cultural layers as well as secondary burials (see Larsson 2003; von Hackwitz 2009; Wallin 2017; Lindström 2020). Additionally, archaeology can trace religious transmission between the Pitted Ware culture, Comb Ceramic culture and to a lesser extent to the Corded Ware culture. Tracing this transmission within Pitted Ware culture mortuary practice might aid in untangling the intricacies that still puzzle archaeologists today. Further, by application of ritual theory as well as ethnographic and historical analogies, the hope is that this methodological framework will provide new insight to the role of the figurine in the Pitted Ware culture's ontological and cosmological world.

1.2 Research question and hypotheses

Research questions

- If the markings on the figurines face and body represent the manipulation and preparation of the deceased ancestor before burial, and is thus given a second and final death by fragmentation.
- Whether the treatment of the figurines as a possible element of ancestral veneration can be understood through ethnographic- and historical analogies.

Hypotheses

1. The Pitted Ware culture figurines represent ancestors in the shape of alloforms having returned to the original soil and cosmos upon death.
2. The figurines represent a reconstruction of wrapping the body before burial and placing plastered death masks over the deceased's face.
3. Lastly, the large presence of figurines at Pitted Ware culture sites such as Tråsättra and Jettböle, and the absence thereof at sites such as Ajvide on Gotland, is a consequence of local circumstantial adaptations.

1.3 Selection and Delimitation

The Pitted Ware culture site of Tråsättra, in the Mälardalen archipelago in eastern Sweden presents a unique opportunity to further understand the belief system of the hunter-gatherers of the Middle Neolithic people of Northern Europe. More specifically, the thesis encompasses the

anthropomorphic figurines found at the Tråsättra site as well as other (mainly) Baltic examples, and how the life-cycle of non-human actors and humans can be intertwined in ways that are hard for us modern humans to fully grasp. Furthermore, Tråsättra was also selected because the Baltic type of figurine is presented there in an abundance not seen at other Pitted Ware culture locations on mainland Sweden, or in the Baltic area. The only settlement of similar nature, and that is somewhat geographically close, is situated on the Finnish island of Åland, in Jettböle, Jomala Parish in the Baltic Sea. The thesis will focus on elucidating the cosmological and ontological meaning attributed to the figurines; with the main focus highlighting the possibility of ancestral worship and mortuary practice exercised through the corporality of the figurines. This topic was selected because no research has been sufficiently aimed towards the discourse of ancestral veneration in the matter of Pitted Ware culture iconographic representation. Especially considering the fact that theories surrounding ancestral cults are not unheard of regarding the Pitted Ware culture in earlier studies - although not within the scope of figurine representation. In addition, ethnographic- and historical analogy as well as comparative analysis of mainly hunter-gatherer groups of the circum-polar zone, Northern Europe and Eurasia present the analytical tool for the study, as well as selected analogies from similar but more geographically and culturally distant traditions. The selection of sites is based on their relevancy in providing analogous and comparative material, either in ritual practices, mortuary traditions or in the material record. Most sites inhabit several or all of the above mentioned elements.

1.4 Material

The presentation of the Tråsättra settlement will be predominantly based on the excavation report of the site, written by Björck *et al.* (2020), at Arkeologerna SHM (Statens Historiska Museum). The main focus lies with the figurines, which will be presented here. For this reason, the settlement itself will be presented through a briefer overview, where relevant aspects of the site will be selected and presented. Where certain settlement details have been excluded, it is because they are deemed as not being relevant for the study at hand. The Neolithic sites of Jettböle and Geta on Åland, Ajvide on Gotland as well as the Gipka-Purciems site in Northern Kurzeme and the burial- and settlement site of Zvejnieki in Latvia will be presented (fig. 1). These are all sites that in some way relate to, remind of and/or can provide analogies and comparative data for the present study.

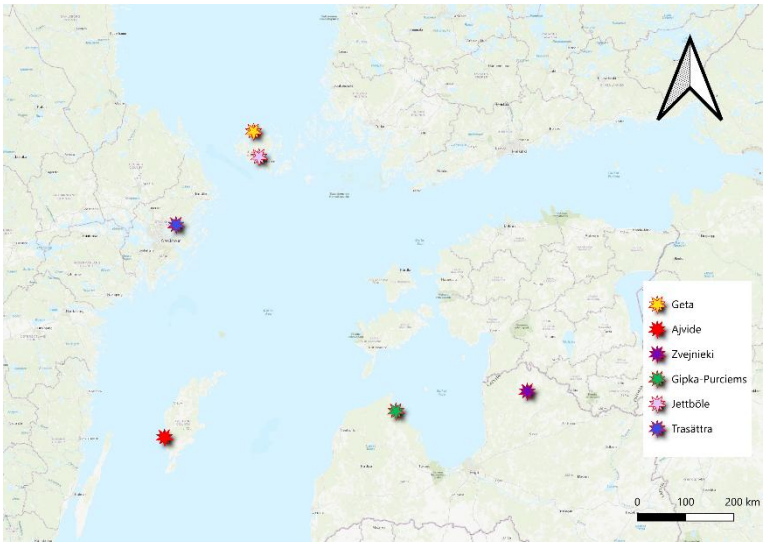


Figure 1. Map of the select Neolithic hunter-gatherer sites around the Baltic Sea coast where clay figurines have been represented in the archaeological material.

1.4.1 Tråsättra and the figurines

The Middle Neolithic site of Tråsättra is as previously stated situated in the Mälardalen archipelago, in Eastern Sweden. It sits in a bay of what thousands of years ago was an island that was part of a greater network of islands in the Baltic Sea archipelago. Its location in the topography is typical for Pitted Ware culture settlements of Mälardalen; it sits at approx. 27 m.a.s.l (meters above sea level), and is facing south, protected from wind and weather by big blocks of bedrock to the west and east of the residential huts. The hypothesised longest possible period of habitation at the Tråsättra settlement was between 2890–2290 BC. "Hypothesised" is due to the uncertainty of the actual continuous period of habitation; hence, the dating was divided into two models/options. The settlement was either inhabited 2700–2400 BC or 2577–2465 BC, however I deem it superfluous to go into further detail of all the different phases of the settlement; the relevant phase for this thesis is the period between *approx.* 2525–2480 BC. This spans over phase 2, and some of phase 3 of both dating models, and represents the most active period of the settlement, as well as the period when there is an increase in ritual activity (for details on the dating models, see Björck 2020). The economy of the settlement is a typical hunter-fisher-gatherer ideology, with a special focus towards seal hunting and fishing. The entire area of excavation was 2800 m². 433 features saw the light of day and were interpreted as belonging to approx. five or six huts about 12–17 m^2 in size and seventeen other constructions relating to said huts. Within the constellation of huts was the so-called central area of 15x15 m, which was the area where most of the day-to-day activity took place. Visible burials are relatively few compared to the number of presumed inhabitants which is four–six individuals per hut over several generations; the burial features amount to eight graves. It is possible that the graves were reused for several individuals over time. No human skeletal elements remain due to the acidic soil, however phosphate analysis as well as find contexts support this claim - see below. Six of the graves (A1109, A1249, A1269, A1292, A1323 and A5134) are situated to the north of the central area, and two (A10089 and A11001) are right next to hut two and three which sets them apart from the other six (Björck *et al.* 2020: 11–13, 18, 25, 32, 95). Five of the graves are of particular character in the form of holding a layer of red ochre, and four graves had inconspicuous smaller, dug-out features attached to their long side. Four fragments of anthropomorphic figurines were found divided over three graves; one figurine fragment was found in grave A1109, one figurine fragment was found in a pin hole feature (A516) slightly north of grave A1323, two figurine fragments were found in grave A10089 next to hut three. Hut tree displays a ritual use that cannot be discerned in the other huts; ceramics, animal bones as well as intentionally deposited ceramic vessels in very close proximity to the hut. The vessels had been deposited in a large, stone-lined posthole. In the posthole, there was possibly a mounted log, perhaps with inscriptions for the purpose of ritual or ceremonial use, as suggested by Björck *et al.* (2020: 12). Flint debitage, seal bones and ceramics were also found in some of the graves, and many of the graves had post- and/or pin holes or pits in their close proximity. Possibly, these were grave markers or smaller fence constructions relating to the graves. Adding to this, there are also some features, such as construction A1140 showing signs of ritual activity, situated in the easternmost location of the area of huts. A1140 was sealed off from the central area with a fence or palisade construction. No human remains could be found anywhere at the site, although both burnt and unburnt animal bones were found in the central area where the chemistry of the soil had been altered due to the daily activities of the group. For bones to last, the soil requires a certain level of stability, limited permeability, and alkalinity. The ceramics and bones deposited in the central area of the huts may therefore have acted as a buffer, making the soil suitable for preserving unburnt bones (Björck *et al.* 2020: 168-169). Regarding the unburnt bones, however, these may also be burned but at a lower temperature. The settlement is a part of a bigger network in the area, consisting of perhaps four or five locations (Björck *et al.* 2020: 31). Certain finds and recent ICP-MA/ES (Inductively Coupled Plasma Mass Atomic Emission Spectrometry) analysis of several figurines also speak for long distance trade, originating from Baltic islands as well as northern Sweden, more on this later.

The main material of focus is of course the figurines. The excavation at Tråsättra, led by Niclas Björck at Arkeologerna SHM in 2016, resulted in 329 figurine fragments of the western type, weighing 1,76 kg. Around 85 % of these fragments could be identified as figurines, however only eight figurines could be re-assembled into a coherent whole (Björck *et al.* 2020: 120). The figurines at Tråsättra are anthropomorphic, zoomorphic and possibly human-animal hybrids. Displaying bodies of burnt clay, their size varies from very small fragments of feet or heads, to contextually large heads and bodies. The sizes of the figurines range from 3–20 cm and the heads are tilted towards the sky in an adorning position (fig. 1). Some have holes running along the very top of the head (fig. 2), possibly meant to hold feathers, sticks or grass to resemble hair (Björck *et al.* 2020: 16). Their faces are often marked with dotted lines, tracing the chin up towards the lips, much like a beard. Dotted lines also follow the forehead down to the eyes and cheeks, and occasionally over the nose bridge - much similar to the *kakiniit tattoo* of the circumpolar inuit culture, where the term Kakiniit is an umbrella term holding several tattoos that women receive to mark different milestones in their life journeys, such as entering adulthood (Abdulhak 2024: 43, 44). Their bodies hold patterns that could resemble clothes, or body wrappings, which is what this thesis aims to examine. 75 % of the figurines are labeled anthropomorphic, and the rest are labeled as animals or objects; with an over-representation of seal. The figurines have no crystal clear interpretations, and although they are labeled as anthropomorphic or zoomorphic, these are solely qualified guesses. Some figurines labeled as anthropomorphic transgress the animal/human dichotomy, such as figurine nr. 101 (fig. 3), which could be a person, a bear or a hybrid. Some cannot be labeled at all, and some seem to depict what can possibly be small drums or miniature vessels. All of the figurines, both the anthropomorphic and the zoomorphic, have been seemingly intentionally broken and scattered around the central area in between the huts. This pattern of depositing clay figurines in a central area adjacent to the huts is also represented at Fräkenrönningen, where all of the fragments from 26 figurines were found right outside the huts. One exception was hut HG VII that was twice as large as the other huts, held more intact pottery, three figurines and had a grave cutting into the foundation stones (‘väggröse’ in Swedish). Fräkenrönningen also held large amounts of red ochre, covering the whole floor of several huts as well as in clumps scattered over the settlement floor (Björck 1998: 54–58). Hut VII reminds of the relationship between hut three and grave A10089 at Tråsättra. The same depositional pattern related to huts and post holes can also be seen in other Neolithic settlements around the Baltic.



Figure 2. Figurine no. 95 with upwards tilt of the head and holes along the back of the scalp. Photo: Maja Hed. Accessed thanks to Arkeologerna SHM.



Figure 3. Figurine nr 101. Bear, human or both?
Photo: Maja Hed. Accessed thanks to Arkeologerna SHM.

1.4.2 Jettböle, Jomala Parish, Åland island, Finland

Before presenting the location and material of the Jettböle settlement, it is important to mention the difficulties therein. Since the excavation and the majority of the documentation of this site took place in the beginning of the 20th century as well as in the beginning of the 21st century, sources are scarce. The only primary source of the initial excavation is Björn Cederhvarfs brief description of the locale and its contents from 1912. Therefore, I have been forced to utilize secondary sources of the matter such as Niklas Stenbäck's dissertation from 2003, and research papers. Beginning with presenting the location; this settlement on the beach of the Åland archipelago was initially excavated in the very beginning of the 20th century by Björn Cederhvarf and his colleagues. Jettböle is of similar characteristics and displays parallels in topographical location in the landscape, culture, economy, cosmology and ontology as the Tråsättra settlement on the mainland. Jettböle also displays a continuous use spanning over a large time scale and across cultural transformation and development; the ceramics found here display Comb Ceramic culture as well as Pitted Ware culture, and there is also a small amount of pottery of the Battle Axe culture present (Stenbäck 2003: 168). Jettböle also presents similar ritualistic features as Tråsättra, such as inconspicuous post holes with darker soil, as well as red ochre features, and peculiar ways of handling human remains, and a very strong entanglement with seals and fish (Lucenius 2021: 137, 138), as these constituted their most important source of sustenance - this will be discussed further in the analysis. Thanks to the calcareous soil on Åland, bones from both humans and animals have been preserved, and burnt human bones were scattered in the cultural layer of the older settlement (Lucenius 2021: 134). The sites relevant to this study are Jettböle I active around 3350–2600 BC and Jettböle II active around 2900–2200 BC (Lucenius 2021: 127), whereas Jettböle II is the area where the figurines were found. Jettböle I is the location where the graves and scattered human remains were found.

A. Jettböle I (3350–2600 BC)

Jettböle I was at the time of its settlement phase facing northwest, where it was protected from wind and weather by the Jettböle mountain. The oldest phase of this location - Jettböle Bergmanstorp, and Jettböle I also display a certain tradition in ceramic manufacture that tells of a clever way of re-cycling old material, but also re-connecting with the previous Comb Ceramic culture settlers. They used older Comb Ceramic culture crushed pottery to temper Pitted Ware culture pottery, which is an occurrence sometimes seen in transitions between periods (Lucenius 2021: 127, 130). Within Jettböle I is *trench A,* which is where the vast

majority of the human and animal bones of Jettböle were deposited. Trench A was 99 m^2, within which was square LXVII and square LXVI. In square LXVII there was a large concentration of incomplete human skeletons, at that time interpreted as disturbed graves. Trench A also incorporated 18.000 stone artefacts and 38.500 potsherds, as well as rich amounts of unburnt animal and human bones. A large part of the trench has, however, been damaged by gravel quarrying. Apart from square LXVII, the majority of the human remains were scattered and commingled in the cultural layer. The bones were predominantly upper body elements such as skull fragments and mandibles, as well as teeth. The bones show cut marks and intentional breaking of mostly the long bones, which has been suggested as a sign of cannibalism or complex mortuary rituals. Many elements of the human body are missing; in fact, out of the 13 individuals that made up the bone assemblage, only 58 % of the expected skeletal remains could be accounted for. They may have been destroyed by disturbances, or purposefully deposited elsewhere - perhaps even in the ocean. There is no specific age distribution (Götherström *et al.* 2002: 46–49).

B. Jettböle II (2900–2200 BC)

Unfortunately, Jettböle II is not as well documented as Jettböle I, so what little information is available will be presented here. Jettböle II was the main trench of investigation during Cederhvarfs excavations in 1906 and 1908, and this is where the figurines first saw the light of day. The figurines at Jettböle are of the same type (western) as Tråsättra (fig. 4), and Cederhvarf found fragments constituting approx. 60 figurines (Cederhvarf 1912: 3), all of which were supposedly intentionally broken (Stenbäck 2003: 170). The figurine fragments were found somewhat evenly scattered in the trenches of Jettböle II, together constituting an excavated area of 90 m^2 (Cederhvarf 1912: 8). In the western part of the trench were three dug-out pits, 1.2 m big (it is not specified in the reference if it is the width, the depth or the diameter), which contained rich amounts of pitch black fatty soil. Battle Axe culture ceramics were also represented in small amounts in this trench. The preservational qualities of the soil are suboptimal at Jettböle II, but there were still a scarce number of unburnt human bones, although in lesser quantity. A quite large amount of seal skulls was concentrated in the eastern parts of the trench, along with the human bones. Jan Storå suggests that there is a visible structural change in the transition between Jettböle I and Jettböle II, where seal hunting takes a new and more symbolic role in the belief system of the Jettböle inhabitants. The figurines were as aforementioned scattered all over the trench, but just like the seal skulls and the human remains, there was a somewhat larger concentration in the eastern parts of the trench (Stenbäck 2003: 164–169).



Figure 4. Western type figurine from Jettböle II.

Source: Haverinen, Markku. KM 5180:57, Finnish Heritage Agency.

1.4.3 Östergeta 16.9, Geta municipality, Åland Islands, Finland

Östergeta, commonly referred to as simply “Geta”, is located on a peninsula shooting out into the Bothnian Bay. The locale has a long continuity stretching from the Neolithic into the Iron Age. During the Neolithic, the site was inhabited by a hunter-gatherer community of mainly Pitted Ware culture, but also Kiukais culture as well as the pastoralist Corded Ware culture. During the for this thesis relevant period of habitation, the settlement was located on a sheltered flat and sandy beach, which today is a beach-terrass approx. 38 m.a.s.l. The excavation of the site is not yet finished, and it will continue during the summer of 2026 as it is a field school project run by Jan Fast and Janne Soisalo. For this reason, the interpretations made in this thesis are preliminary and might change as excavation continues. During the excavations conducted between 2021–2025, the site has revealed similar features to both Tråsättra and Ajvide. Excavations at Geta revealed a fatty black surface, in which at least 40 figurine fragments of the western type were found. Just as at Ajvide, the black soil reeked of seal oil. The figurines of Geta are very similar to those found at Tråsättra and Jettböle, showing drop shaped bodies with patterns reminiscent of clothes and wrappings (fig. 5). One figurine showed traces of having been mended with tree-sap, revealing that it had broken before its use-life was finished. Several thousand bone fragments and 400kg of debitage from stone tool working was also represented at the location. The skeletal remains were mainly from seal, bird and fish according to the initial analysis from the survey of 1984. The more recently found bone material will be analysed after the excavation is fully completed.



Figure 5. Figurine fragments from the Geta settlement.
Photos: Jan Fast, 2025.

During the third year of excavating, four circles of unburnt stone came to light. These are very inconspicuous and there is no clear interpretation as to their purpose. They show no signs of burning, however they are covered in the same black sooty and oily sand that the figurines were found in. One of the circles had a flat slab of sandstone at the bottom, beneath which there was clean untouched sand. These stone circles are hard to interpret - they are not postholes, nor are they hearths despite the soot (Fast & Soisalo, Östergeta 16.9 excavation reports 2021–2025). I would suggest that these were working surfaces where burnt remains of varying kinds were prepared for their later utilization, although with the material available at the time of writing this thesis (spring 2026), it is hard to say if it was for ritual or everyday use. There are no graves, nor any huts mentioned to exist in the nearby vicinity, so it is possible that this was a location individuals visited as a seasonal ceremonial site much like the Gipka-Purciems settlement in Latvia. What can be said about the site is that it holds, as mentioned, similarities to both Ajvide and Tråsättra, and in extension also Jettböle through the likeness of the figurines. Jan Fast will release the book “Blickar från Stenåldern” on the Geta settlement in 2027.

1.4.4 Gipka-Purciems Ritual Settlement, Northern Kurzeme

In Latvia, in northern Kurzeme is the Neolithic settlement of Gipka-Purciems, dated to 2800–2500 BC and belonging to the local culture of pit-ceramics. This location relates to this thesis as it displays similarities and direct parallels to both Tråsättra and Jettböle. The locations are Gipka A and B, as well as Purciems C and F, located on the sand dunes of what was once situated between the littoral of the Littorina Sea and the Gipka Lagoon (Loze 2005: 155; Loze 2008: 54). Here, fragments of 20 figurines of the western type were found around the different locations (see Loze 2005 fig. 3, 8). The Gipka A settlement is particularly complex in the manner of ritual manifestation, and might aid in tracing the wider belief system related to hunter-gatherers and Pit-Comb cultures in the Baltic. The figurines found at Gipka-Purciems are all fragmented and depict hints of being part of a ritualistic ceremonies, and numbers of them inhabit both aesthetic details as well as manufacturing and destruction details that brings one to think of Tråsättra and Jettböle. The Gipka-Purciems figurines display facial features that comparatively resemble the ones at Tråsättra, with the linear patterns tracing the area from the chin to the mouth, as well as lines going down the nose bridge. The bodies share the same honey-comb pattern (Bērziņš 2008: 189) as well as dotted, zig-zag and striped patterns as many of the Tråsättra and Jettböle figurines and what is more, is that they share the same upwards tilt of the face towards the sky. However, a few figurines separate themselves from the rest; these are the figurines with projected legs of Gipka A and B. Likely, this was done so to make them stand up in the sand; a similar function can be seen in the feet of a few figurines of Tråsättra as well. These have holes under their feet (fig. 6), probably used in the same manner as the Latvian figurines. Moulding projected legs in the Tråsättra figurines would most likely not be very helpful in regards to the muddier and more compact soil of the coastal settlement, whereas a skinnier, sturdy stick or small piece of bone would penetrate the soil more effectively. Another type is a bead shaped anthropomorphic head found at Gipka B, although the author of this thesis suspects this could be a case of pareidolia. Ilze Loze believes the location of Gipka A to be a seasonal ceremonial gathering location for the groupings of hunter-gatherers in the area, and finds of pit-ceramic evokes theories of intricate networks of trade and cultural interconnection between Finland and Scandinavia (Loze 2005: 164, 167). Additionally, Gipka A presents copious amounts of red ochre, an element that is very common in ritual settings in prehistory (Bērziņš 2008: 392). According to Loze, the great amount of red ochre found around the settlement by hearths and palisades was an important element in reanimating the clay figurines and later breaking them when the ritual is finished (2005: 163). The palisades of Gipka represent a phenomenon that often is attributed to sites imbued with ritual, such as the numerous Lengyel culture circular palisade enclosures of the Moravia territory, whereas one palisade held 375 female figurines (Kreiter *et al.* 2024: 3; Kanakova and Nosek 2025: 1–3). However these figurines are *not* figuratively similar to the Tråsättra figurines, or any of the other ones in this thesis but can nonetheless aid as comparative material.



Figure 6. Figurine foot from Tråsättra with a hole.
Photo by Maja Hed. Accessed thanks to Arkeologerna SHM.

1.4.5 Zvejnieki settlement and burial ground, Northern Latvia

The Zvejnieki burial- and settlement ground is located in Northern Latvia on the shore of Lake Burtnieks. This locale is mainly attributed to the Neolithic Comb Ceramic culture as well as the Middle Mesolithic 7310–7050 BC to 2890–2620 BC, and it holds a continuity of site usage as well as ritual traditions that is extraordinary in the Baltic archaeological record. The Mesolithic site is called Zvejnieki II and the Neolithic site is called Zvejnieki I. Representing one of the largest and most significant burial sites in Northern Europe, it holds over 300 graves. What makes this site so extraordinary is not simply the amount of graves, but also that the site is so well preserved and reveals mortuary traditions and religious patterns that are hard to reach under normal circumstances due to decomposition. The cultural layer of Neolithic Zvejnieki I was 0,7–0,8 m thick, and black from all the decaying organic material (Larsson *et al.* 2017: 57–64). Figurines found at Zvejnieki are a scarce amount, only 14 distributed over eleven burials, whereas one of them was of the clay eastern Baltic type and two of the clay western Baltic type (Larsson *et al.* 2017: 64). Another anthropomorphic clay figurine was found but the type remains unknown. The rest were made from antler, bone and stone. All the figurines represent either birds, cervids, aquatic animals or humans. The eastern Baltic type figurine was found between the ribs of a child, and two amber rings at the child's head suggests a clay death mask. The child was laid to rest on a thick layer of red ochre (Zagorska *et al.* 2018: 100, 112). Nevertheless, the site is relevant to this thesis as it is part of the same cultural sphere as the Pitted Ware culture, as well as inhabiting a similar economy of hunting, gathering and fishing as well as ritual practices in the shape of fragmentation, red ochre features/graves and ancestral veneration. These variables manifest in various ways; younger generations were buried in a manner that disturbed and cut into the graves of older generations. This led to bones of various individuals being commingled in the soil, simultaneously as this commingled soil was used to fill in newer graves (Nilsson Stutz 2021: 19). What is more, is that the soil used to fill graves also held fragmented pottery, flint projectile points and amber ornaments. Out of the over 300 graves of Zvejnieki, 164 of them had red ochre to a larger or lesser extent, and group graves as well as children's graves held the most ochre as well as the most intentionally fragmented artifacts. In fact, 90 % of children's graves had red ochre. Another discernible pattern is that although the ochre burials were more common during the Mesolithic - going into the Early Neolithic period, red ochre was still mostly in group graves but it also began to occur more

often around the head. As the settlement transitions into the Middle Neolithic phase, red ochre use diminished drastically but it was still fairly common to find covering the heads of buried individuals. During this phase, there is instead an increase in placing grave goods heavily stained with red ochre along the outlines of the graves (Zagorska 2008: 117–122). It is further noteworthy that there are numerous cases of wrapped burials at Zvejnieki, and what is more, is that in the cases of wrapped burials red ochre is nearly always present. Ochre covering the heads has been interpreted as ochre stained plastered death masks, in addition to amber discs in the place where the eyes orifices would be (Elliott *et al.* 2021: 708–709). Although there are very few clay figurines at Zvejnieki, figurines of perishable material such as bone and antler are more present, revealing a figural tradition was present even if it was not through the medium of clay. Additionally, a few clay figurines were excavated in close relation to pottery of the Corded Ware culture (Larsson *et al.* 2017: 61).

1.4.6 The Ajvide burial ground L1977:1025, Gotland, Sweden

Concerning the discussion of ancestral cults and veneration within the Pitted Ware culture, one must bring the Ajvide site into the equation. This is because even though the Ajvide site provides no anthropomorphic figurines, the site presents valuable information regarding mortuary customs that cannot be seen on the mainland due to poor preservation conditions. With that in mind, local customs may vary between the mainland and the islands in the Baltic Sea - but it nevertheless provides insight and beneficial data for the comparison and analyzing of the Tråsättra site and its material. Ajvides calcareous soil allows organic material to be preserved, and therefore the burial ground of Ajvide and its circumstances will provide exceptional analogous data for the understanding of Pitted Ware culture cosmology and ontology. Excavations at Ajvide were conducted over 24 years, excavating over 3000 m^2. Three settlement phases could be discerned from phosphate surveys and overall settlement analysis; *1*. 3200–2900 BC, revealing that the settlement abided by a maritime economy with some features of swine herding. This initial phase also traces that swine may have been ritually slaughtered for feasting. *2.* In this second phase 2900–2600 BC, mortuary practice can reveal that there was a shift in how the settlement perceived the relationship between older and younger generations. The deceased were now being buried in the older cultural layer, reconnecting with the ancestors. *3.* During the third phase 2600–2300 BC, a larger ritualization of the settlement is displayed. Dark black and fatty surfaces are found during excavation interpreted as a ceremonial seal-slaughtering ground usually referred to as the *Käut-altare* (seal-altar), and an intermixture of Battle Axe culture and Pitted Ware culture burial traditions can be spotted in graves bearing battle axes and hocker positioned bodies. Although, no Battle Axe culture settlements have yet been found on Gotland (Wallin 2017: 118). The burial ground holds a massive number of 85 graves and 89 individuals, as well as palisade-like constructions and hundreds of postholes (see Sjöstrand & Wallin 2017; Sjöstrand 2022). Elements of particular mortuary practices here are present in ways that have got no direct equal in abundance on the mainland, such as the scattered human remains, cenotaphs and missing upper body elements. Cenotaphs, which are empty burials, could be interpreted as make-shift graves for members of the group that have been lost at sea or that never came back from their journeys. The black surfaces however, has perhaps recently found an equal at the Östergeta site on the Åland Islands, as mentioned above. There were four so-called black surfaces found at Ajvide, containing high amounts of faunal remains from mainly seals and fish, but also pottery of the type usually found in graves at the site. Three of the four black surfaces contained clusters of scattered human remains, revealing that the surfaces had a ceremonial significance in relation to mortuary practice and ancestral veneration. Surface nr. 1 and nr. 3 had postholes outlining them, with a possible oval hut being identified amongst the postholes of surface nr. 3 (Sjöstrand 2022: 29–32). This can be interpreted as perhaps an ossuary for the ritual manipulation of bones from both humans and animals. As aforementioned, no anthropomorphic figurines have been found at Ajvide. In fact, only three figurines presumably all depicting seals have been found on the

island as a whole, and anthropomorphic figurines are nowhere to be found, at the time of writing this thesis. The 3000 m^2 excavated area at Ajvide is situated at the Neolithic shoreline around twelve m.a.s.l (Sjöstrand 2022: 9, 20) and survived on a mainly fisher-hunter-gatherer economy, with a large focus on seal and fish. The site of Ajvide shows promise in understanding the relationship between particularly seals and humans, but also the Pitted Ware culture's relationship to water in their cosmology (see Hed 2021).

1.4.7. Fragmentation within the Pit-Comb cultural sphere

The hunter-gatherers of the Pit-Comb horizon emerged around the boreal forest belt as a continuation of a process that likely had its origins in the Russian far east Amur Valley within the Osipovka and Gromatukha cultures in the Late Glacial around 14,000–8000 BC (Shoda 2020: 1–2). Subsequently, the manufacturing tradition of comb and pit impressions spread to eastern Siberia, where the Ust'Karenga culture ceramic served as an early prototype of the combed ceramic that would eventually disperse westward over the Urals around 7000 BC and by 6000 BC, the tradition had spread to the Upper Volga region. Around 5000 BC the Comb Ceramic culture was its own archaeological complex, spreading to southeastern Finland and continued to the Arctic. The culture was never fully established in Sweden until it arrived in Ostrobothnia around 3000 BC (Nũnez 2010: 220–221). The early Neolithic phase of the Comb Ceramic culture, the Typical Comb Ware culture (3900–3500 BC), is often associated with fragmented slate rings, typically found in Finland and somewhat in Estonia. These were mostly made from slate, or metatuff imported from Russian Karelia. The rings were in the majority of cases fragmented into two or more pieces, and although most did not, some had drilled holes or grooves aimed for suspension. These rings have been theorized as part of an enchainment system of gift-giving, but also as protective talismans connected to certain people and/or certain places. Out of the 246 fragments found as of 2022, 19 were found in graves and the remaining part were found in the occupational layers of settlements. Nästinristi and Törmävaara in Finland held very large concentrations in their cultural layers, which has been interpreted as intentional deposition at a place that held significance to the group or groups that frequented the location (Ahola 2022: 1264–1273). Fragmentation is also seen in graves - projectile points, amber pendants, ceramic vessels, and in some rare occasions figurines made from bone or antler. The latter was possibly more established as a tradition than the material record makes light of due to decomposition. Red ochre is a very common element in Comb Ceramic culture graves, as well as placing ceramic rims by the head of the deceased and scattering red ochre over their faces and sometimes the entire body. Miniature vessels are sometimes placed upside down in the graves, and at the Zvejnieki burial ground in northern Latvia, skulls were occasionally plastered with blue clay mixed with red ochre (Zagorska 2001: 112).

1.5 Source criticism

1.5.1 Ritual labeling

Applying ritualistic meaning to archaeological sites has been met with a certain resistance, especially during the 60s and 70s, when archaeologists had the unfortunate rumor of labeling whatever unexplainable archeological phenomena they encountered as "ritual". Entering more modern times, the paradigm shifted and the dogma regarding ritual, cult and religious variables to the science of archaeology evolved as it became an accepted reality that ritual is a deeply integrated part (conscious or unconscious) in the socio-cultural structure of prehistory (Kaliff 2007: 20). Nevertheless, even if ritual is certainly important and well imbued in prehistoric society, critical thinking is crucial as to not label every mysterious occurrence as ritual; at least not in a "religious" sense. What I mean by "religious" is that while many rituals are related to

religious or spiritual practices, such as worship or offerings to deities, rituals can also be mundane in the sense of being a routine that is performed without religious connotations. It can sometimes be difficult to separate the religious- and spiritual rituals from the mundane (routines, habits, norms). Especially since many rituals can be both simultaneously. In this thesis, labeling an occurrence as ritualistic is done when the find-context, use-life and handling of the encountered phenomena agrees more with ritual use, than non-ritualistic, functional and/or mundane use.

1.5.2 Alternative reasons for figurine breakage

There is also a need to address the difference in the clay composition of figurines from the eastern type and the figurines from the western type. The western and younger type of figurine was manufactured from more porous clay than the eastern and older ones (Kashina 2019: 467), which could be an explanation to why the western type is found fragmented in the majority of cases, while the eastern type is quite often found intact. The western type and younger type, which include the Pitted Ware culture figurines are also larger, which in combination with the more porous clay diminishes their structural integrity. Nor are there any signs of intentional fragmentation with the aid of tools. There are no cut marks from sawing, bashing or cutting the figurines. It is also possible that the daily activity at the location has contributed at least partially to the fragmentation of the figurines. Of course, 5000 years of weather, human- and animal activity, shifting stratigraphy and other disturbances could be responsible for part of the breakage. Further, it cannot be ruled out that the figurines of the eastern and western types were utilized in different manners, since there can be local variations of traditions over geographical and temporal distances.

1.5.3 Unbiased sources

A few of the sources for this thesis are quite old, and others are from regions that have undergone political conflict, such as Russia. The reason for this disclaimer is that in researching the topic of figurines within the Pit-Comb cultures, it is unavoidable to not encounter Russian research since many of said cultures existed in that area. The Soviet regime has a problematic past in regards to archaeology, but not in regards to the empirical material itself, it has rather been a matter of ideological interpretations *of* said material (see Ojala 2016, chapter 7; Klejn 2017). Besides, the research regarding the Stone- and Bronze Age has at large been unbiased and well conducted even during the Soviet regime. Most countries, even Sweden, have had periods of nationalistic influence on research. For more on this topic, see Bozena Werbart's (now Wyzsomierska) and Evert Baudou's debate in the journal *Fornvännen* (Baudou 2000; Werbart 2000; Baudou 2001). Further, primary sources such as original excavation reports have been incredibly hard to locate regarding the Baltic sites. If they exist, they are physically stored in libraries or archives in their respective countries and not open-source accessible, or they are old enough that they likely exist in an archive somewhere, but its location is not stated anywhere. Attempts to contact archaeologists that participated in these Baltic excavations in e.g. Latvia, has been unsuccessful as emails have remained unanswered. This has forced me to utilize scientific research articles, books and journals that themselves either discuss these reports, sites, and figurines, or literature authored by archaeologists that participated in the excavations themselves. With that said, *all* literature used in this thesis has been thoroughly evaluated to avoid bias and outdated research. Regarding using old sources, this has only been done if the research is deemed still relevant and useful to this thesis. These sources might use outdated language, such as the derogatory term "*eskimo*", and while I use the correct term "*inuit*" in the text, I have chosen not to change this word in the reference list so as to correctly reference the research.

2. Research background

2.1 Figurines in the Prehistoric World: Power, creation, destruction

The European Neolithic is extraordinary in its representation of figural art. Prehistoric anthropomorphic figurines have always caught the eye and interest of archaeologists world wide. What are they? Are they toys? Protective amulets? Reborn ancestors? All, or perhaps none of the above? Trying to decipher what ontological value prehistoric figurines possessed is a difficult task and the discourse has ever so often been drawn towards cult, ritual, religion and mysticism. Simultaneously, figurines in prehistory seem to transcend the dualistic *either/or* principle of the positivist philosophy; only what can be seen and logically assumed can be true. The truth is subjective, and figurines in prehistory are time and again proven to be untethered from trivial categories such as gender, animal/human, age, divine, mundane etc. (Insoll 2017: 3–16). A great example of the aforementioned are the very figurines central to this thesis - the *western type* Baltic figurine. Further ethnographical comparison will be discussed later in this thesis. Lynn Meskell, archaeologist and professor of anthropology at the University of Pennsylvania, stresses that figurines need to be viewed and interpreted within their own sphere of social interaction, meaning that for these cultures they represent something real, and what is *real* cannot always be deduced to the manifested physicality of something (Meskell 2017: 18). In order to attempt to understand them in this physical world, but also the *metaphysical* world, we must first understand that they are equally *alive* as their creators. These non-human actors serve as conduits of the lived and experienced world, and they are as agential as they are powerful. They communicate, narrate, represent, express and connect people over time and space. Christopher Witmore (2014: 210–212) argues that to further grasp the social fabric and structure of (pre)history, we need to study *things* as *participants*, and not solely passive inanimate objects without agency or intention. Thus, how they are created, treated and disposed of can reveal more of the figurine than its aesthetic values.

2.1.1 The life of the figurine

In this paragraph, focus will be directed towards the research regarding the life-cycles of figurines in a wider general scope, and not solely focus on the Pitted Ware culture figurines of Tråsättra. This is in view of the fact that figurines are not in any manner, exclusive to Sweden or even Scandinavia or Northern Europe. Northern Europe figural representation is, in comparison to Southeast Europe and Southwest Asia, fairly scarce (Iversen *et al*. 2024: 601). This begs for the need to go further and beyond. It is relevant to this thesis to discuss the research regarding the creation as well destruction of figurines, as well as other elements relating to their use-life. Several scholars within the discipline have touched on the subject of fragmentation and its interpretation and meaning in history (see Chapman & Gayderska 2007; Burström 2013; Scarre 2017). One must mention John Chapman's early contribution regarding the entanglement, enchainment and relationship between objects, places and people. Chapman's *enchainment theory* widened the discourse of fragmentation, positing that the fragmentation and dispersal of objects as well as human and animal remains into specific contexts such as graves and pits, is an intricate part of the social life-cycle between humans and non-human actors. Fragmentation, according to Chapman, is moreover not exclusive to figurines or ceramics but the most common fragmentation is of skulls and/or the longer bones (i.e the femur etc.) of a body. He also states that cenotaphs in extension could also be perceived as a sort of

fragmentation, perhaps connecting to ancestral worship and the agency of objects, as well as enchainment to places (2000: 5, 6). The cenotaph could represent community members deceased during travels, creating a make-shift grave or altar to remember and honor the lost member. Although Chapman's focus lies in the Balkan Neolithic and Chalcolithic, his ideas and theories are heavily applicable to the theoretical framework that is the life-cycle of the Baltic Neolithic figurines; which encompasses the Pitted Ware figurines. The theory of intentional fragmentation was also a resort to critique towards the strictly functionalistic and processual theories of the relationship between "waste" and site formation studies (Sörman *et al*. 2024: 2). Chapman and Gayderska refer to the figurines of Dolnoslav tell (2007: 130), and argue that the "in-between" time period of a figurines life-cycle is far more ungraspable than the birth (manufacturing) or the death (breaking) of a figurine. At Dolnoslav tell, there are traces of pre-fragmentation or post-fragmentation treatment, but attestation unveiling the mid-life treatment or activities of the figurines are scarce. Here, over 96 % of the 500 figurines were fragmented, some up to five times. Several theories regarding the fragmentation of objects are circulating in the archaeological, anthropological and ethnological/-graphical world. The most common theory is of course ritual; the breaking represents the end of its life-cycle, or a symbolic death. Some (see Fredengren 2018) argue that the breaking and disposal of objects, not solely figurines, is to put it out of circulation so that its power can avoid ending up in the wrong hands. An elucidating example is Iron Age swords, spears, knives etc., which often are found with intentionally bent blades or simply destroyed. This was, almost certainly, because these were personal objects that Iron Age people wanted to bring with them into the afterlife (Aannestad 2018: 148–166). Other analogies can be drawn to Bronze Age depositions in wetlands, as well as depositions of flint axes in lakes during the Neolithic, or fully functioning flint projectiles deposited in settlement layers (Larsson 2011: 69–70).

2.2 Comb Ceramic culture and Pitted Ware culture figurines in general..

This paragraph presents a general overview of the previous research regarding the Baltic type of figurine; that is, the clay figurines found within the Pit-Comb cultural sphere encompassing, amongst others, the Pitted Ware culture as well as the Comb Ceramic culture. See more on this below. Anthropomorphic figurine production started in the boreal forest belt of the European and Asian parts of North Eurasia by the end of the 5th millennia BC. That includes NW Russia (i.e. the republic of Karelia, Leningrad, Vologda, Arkhangelsk) and Latvia, Estonia, Finland and eastern Sweden. The tradition originates within the earliest complex of the Pit-Comb culture, initially made from antler and bone; such as the anthropomorphic figurines from Yuzhniy Oleniy Ostrov by Lake Onega, and the two stray finds from the Pärnu River in Estonia (Jonuks 2021: 104–105). At the Tamula cemetery and settlement site (3800–2800 BC) in southwest Estonia, 13 or 14 anthropomorphic full bodied and flat faced figurines made of bone were found - a uniquely abundant find for the region (Jonuks *et al.* 2024: 97). Although finds of the aforementioned type are scarce in the archaeological record, the Comb Ceramic culture and Pitted Ware culture likely also manufactured figurines from such perishable material, but alas, these would have decayed upon excavation. Further, research can trace three types of hunter-gatherer clay figurines - the *eastern* and *older type* (Porous Ware and Typical Comb Ware culture 3900–3000 BC) of Finland, NW Russia and the Baltic states, and the *western* and *younger* type (Pitted Ware and Late Comb Ceramic culture 3300–2500 BC) in Sweden, Finland and the Baltic states. There is also a mixed type, displaying an overlap in time and space simultaneously through ornamentation and manufacture reminiscent of both the eastern and the western type. This displays at least two waves of figurine distribution and manufacture, with a third "in-between" phase. Based on nearly non-existent finds of clay figurines in central Russia compared to several finds in northern Russia, along with ^{14}C dates from related features, might then indicate that the tradition of clay figurine manufacture started with the eastern type, in SW Finland and South Karelia towards the last phase of the 5th millennia BC. From there, the

tradition evolved and changed into what became the western type in the first half of the 4th millennia BC, spreading to eastern Sweden and Tråsättra, as well as Latvia, Estonia, the Åland islands and South Karelia (Kashina 2023: 466–468). The western type dominates the material of this thesis. I will discuss this cultural transfer later, but previous research can clearly reveal that the Baltic Sea coasts acted as nodes for cultural interaction and transmisson. The eastern and older type is bean or embryo shaped, often with what resembles a dorsal fin along its back (fig. 7). The western and younger type (fig. 2–4) is drop shaped and more richly ornamented. For a more detailed description of the western type, refer to the previous Ch. 1.4.1.



Figure 7. Eastern type figurine. Photo: Suominen, Esa. Finnish Heritage Agency, KM 16366:34.

These anthropomorphs are predominantly found in a state of fragmentation and typically in close proximity to ceremonial features such as black fatty settlement layers, post holes, pit-houses or palisades, as well as settlements interpreted as ceremonial gathering sites (See Loze 2005 & 2008; Björck *et al*. 2020; Fauvelle *et al*. 2025). They are very rarely found in graves. Figurines of predominantly the western type show up in the occupational layers of settlements of various Baltic shores, which display an intricate network of cultural, social and ritual exchange between Neolithic communities. Apart from possibly being tokens of ancestral veneration, they might also have represented relics of an ancient gift-giving network where these figurines were brought along on long journeys to be gifted in ceremonies. Moreover, they could equally have been utilized as protective amulets brought along on long perilous journeys. The Pitted Ware culture thrived between 3200–2300 BC and was characterized by a hunter-gatherer-fishing economy heavily entangled with, and dependent on their surroundings. The name is derived from the characteristics of the ceramic pots and vessels from this culture, which were beautifully ornamented with small holes running along the sides of the vessels. The figurines vary greatly in size, all of them subjected to varying interpretation. Zoomorphic figurines are the most common category of iconographic representation at Pitted Ware culture sites (Björck *et al.* 2020: 121), making the Tråsättra and Jettböle sites exceptions of this rule. Pitted Ware culture anthropomorphic (and zoomorphic) clay figurines, occasionally referred to as the "Jettböle figurines" or clay "idols" as referred to by some, present a unique opportunity to dig deeper into the ontology, as well as cosmology of the Scandinavian Pitted Ware culture. These figurines are unique in more than one sense; firstly they are associated with coastal living Neolithic hunter-gatherers with a mainly maritime economy, while contemporary or earlier figurines from for example the Balkans, Southeast Europe and Southwest Asia are mostly associated with the dawn of agriculture (Iversen *et al.* 2024: 601). Secondly, the ceramic traditions of Baltic hunter-gatherers, including the manufacture of clay figurines, has evolved independently from that of agricultural ceramic traditions (Nũnez 2010: 221). Also, there is

noticeable difference in distribution of figurines in the Eastern and Western Pitted Ware culture settlements - figurines are a much more common occurrence at Pitted Ware culture locales in the east Baltic Sea regions of Sweden, Finland, Estonia, Latvia, Russia and Lithuania, but are much more scarce in Denmark and Kattegatt (Fauvelle *et al*. 2025: 4).

The very first figurines associated with the Pitted Ware culture in Scandinavia was the moose from Åloppe, or "Åloppe-älgen" as it is commonly referred to. The Åloppe moose constituted one out of two figurines resembling moose that were found in 1902, and they present the oldest finds of any sort of figurine in Sweden (Almgren 1906: 110-114; Lindström 2024: 26). Not long after, the first Pitted Ware culture anthropomorphic figurines were found on the Finnish Åland Islands. In the late summer of 1905, an archaeologist with the name of Björn Cederhvarf (1878–1960) initiated excavations at a sandy quarry, in close proximity to Jettböleberget (the Jettböle mountain). The locale was situated at Jettböle, Jomala parrish on the island of Åland - an island that, up until that very summer, was thought to not have been inhabited by humans as far in the past as the Middle Neolithic. This became the first discovered Neolithic settlement on the Åland islands (Cederhvarf 1912: 1; Götherström *et al.* 2002: 42; Stenbäck 2003: 126; Lucenius 2021: 123). At the site of Jettböle (active between 3400–2300 BC), in Jomala parish, fragments constituting approx. 60 anthropomorphic figurines of the western type were unearthed in the beginning of the 1900's by Björn Cederhvarf and his colleagues (Cederhvarf 1912: 3; Stenbäck 2003: 58). Since that extraordinary discovery up until the next equally groundbreaking excavation at the Tråsättra Pitted Ware culture settlement several decades later in 2016, several more Pitted Ware culture settlement sites have been found with anthropomorphic and zoomorphic figurines, although in much lesser quantity. E.g Fräkenrönningen with fragments of approx. 26 figurines (Björck 1998: 57), Arlandastad with fragments of five figurines (Andersson & Werthwein 2012: 19), two almost intact four-legged figurines from Åby in Norrköping municipality (Runeson & Kihlstedt 2018: 72–73), to mention a few. During the process of writing this thesis, a very interesting mixed Pitted Ware culture and Corded Ware culture locale is undergoing current excavation at Geta on the Åland Islands. This locale has so far presented at least 40 fragmented figurines of the western type and is showing great promise for the continued excavations.

2.3 ..and the Tråsättra figurines in particular

In 2016, the Pitted Ware Culture settlement at Tråsättra was discovered and excavated by Arkeologerna/SHM. Here, I will give a brief overview of the figurines, however their contexts, topographical circumstances etc are presented more thoroughly under "Material". At Tråsättra, 329 figurine fragments were found, whereas 75 % of these were anthropomorphic and the remaining 25 % were either zoomorphic or could not be assigned a category because of their ambiguity (Björck *et al.* 2020: 121). These fragments constitute about 100 figurines. The anthropomorphic figurines are cylindrical or drop shaped, decorated and the heads are tilted upwards towards the sky. At the time of discovery, and to this day, no other settlement on mainland Sweden has presented such rich material (Fauvelle *et al.* 2025: 3). In 2020, Arkeologerna SHM released an extensive report of the excavation, and since then several more articles and analyses have been published. The zoomorphic figurines at Tråsättra consist mainly of seals, swine, moose, sea birds and snakes. In many cases it is hard to decipher if a figurine is zoomorphic, anthropomorphic or neither, or both (Björck *et al.* 2020: 16). Tobias Lindström released a Ph.D dissertation discussing the ontological relationship between humans and animals, analyzed through the Pitted Ware Culture figurines. Lindström's interpretation of the figurines as related to hunting ritual and magic (2024: 177), is on the other hand dismissed by Björck in the Tråsättra excavation report, referring to the analyses of the find contexts of the figurines. Moreover, apart from the very majority of the figurines being human depictions, very few of the animals represented in the osteological material (fish, beaver, otter, hare etc.) are represented in the figurines, except seals and a scarce amount of bear, swine, bird and elk. This

points towards that apart from seals and perhaps the fewer animals mentioned above, it is very likely that the remaining animals in the bone assemblage were purely of economic value (Björck *et al.* 2020: 16, 224).

The figurines of Tråsättra are special from several perspectives; they also prove some sort of trade- and cultural exchange network in the Baltic region. ICP-MA/ES analyses from 19 figurines and 39 potsherds from Tråsättra exhibit that the clay used for manufacture originates from both the local clay from the settlement and its near vicinity, but it also shows provenance from Åland and Gotland (Fauvelle *et al.* 2025: 4). Further, Björck *et al.* (2020: 30) suggests the idea of Tråsättra, or another bigger settlement in the area, being a central rendez-vous connection point for other Pitted Ware Culture settlements in the area, perhaps for annual rites or ceremonies. At the Latvian sites of Gipka A, Gipka B and Purciems C, which exhibit extremely similar anthropomorphic figurines, similar theories exist. Ilze Loze (2005: 162) professor emeritus at the University of Riga, posits the idea of the figurines of Gipka-Purciems representing different groupings of people, gathering at a central site during ceremonial rites.

2.4 Interpretations and gaps in the research

What are the interpretations of these mind boggling figurines? And what is missing? Most interpretations regarding the figurines found at Pitted Ware culture sites are centered around what they depict and to a lesser extent what they represent in the relationship between the life-cycle of the figurine and the humans they connect to. They are explained as perhaps being depictions of deities or shamans (Björck *et al*. 2020: 16), tools for hunting magic (Storå 2001: 49; Lindström 2024: 177), or tokens in enchainment traditions through networks of ceremonial gift-giving. Lindström (2024: 177) criticizes the idea that the figurines are tools for hunting magic *through* the fragmentation itself, but rather, he proposes that the figurines were used as a means of affecting the prey animals *before* the fragmentation had occurred. He appoints the fragmentation to natural causes such as firing mishaps, post-depositional damage and wear from their usage. But this leaves one important question unanswered – why could only eight figurines from Tråsättra be reassembled out of the approx. 100 figurines? This question could be answered by the theory of enchainment through gift-giving, where parts of the figurines might have been gifted to other groups or individuals to strengthen bonds and build alliances. That theory is another insufficiently researched trajectory that will require its own elaboration in future studies. Storå (2001) in lieu, suggests that the anthropomorphic figurines are in fact depictions of seals or seal-human hybrids. Storå continues, and suggest that since the cylindrical bodies of the Pitted Ware Culture figurines could be compared to the body shape of seals, and the fact that the figurines found at the Jettböle site were in close proximity to seemingly intentional depositions of seal skulls that this might indicate a special relationship between man and seal (2001: 50, 51). These varying theories might hold some partial truth, and many of them can be applied in some manner to this thesis. For instance, the idea of the figurines as tools for hunting magic *could* be applied to the figurines of Tråsättra; it is a question of interpretation. As stated in the Tråsättra excavation report (2020: 147), a large number of the anthropomorphic figurines could under different circumstances be interpreted as animal-human hybrids, or as assemblages of several different animals. It is many times in the eye of the beholder. This thesis agrees with the anthropomorphic interpretation.

The above-mentioned theories and interpretation will mostly be put aside for this study, reasoning that the present theories and questions need to be thoroughly explored within their own right. Nevertheless, consensus is that they inhabit ritualistic properties that relate to their cosmological and ontological being-in-the-world. There is one aspect of the Pitted Ware Culture religious constitution that I, through my research on the Tråsättra figurines and in extension the Baltic figurines, deem neglected - *ancestral worship*. In my bachelors thesis from 2021 “Death's reflection in the water: Mortuary ritual, ancestral worship and the cosmological significance of water on the island of Gotland during the Pitted Ware Culture” I have already touched on the

subject of ancestral worship within the Pitted Ware Culture, especially at the site of Ajvide on the island of Gotland in the Baltic Sea. However, little research has gone into analyzing the figurines in relation to ancestral cults or mortuary practices. It has been mentioned in passing by, but not critically studied and analyzed on a deeper level. Tõnno Jonuks argues, in passing, that from an anthropological perspective, figurines (in general) are either dead ancestors, spiritual beings, or just regular dolls/toys (2021: 109). Even less research, almost none, has been aimed at examining the figurines as analogies to wrapped bodies and plastered death masks. A number of researchers (see Nilsson Stutz 2006; Zagorska 2008; Ahola 2015; Elliott *et al.* 2021) has researched plastered death masks and wrappings in burials of the Comb Ceramic culture, and aimed the discourse towards what these represent in the Neolithic cosmos. Elliott *et al.* (2021: 711) debate whether the masks represent a liminal membrane or lens, that separates the dead from the living. Stutz briefly mentions that the Baltic western type of figurines sometimes reminds of so-called wrapped burials (2006: 232) - but no further research has examined the matter. In addition to the previously mentioned lack of research regarding death masks and wrapped burials in relation to the Pitted Ware Culture and the figurines, there is nearly no mention of the ritual – and religious connotations of the presence of red ochre and said figurines. Red ochre is after all present in close relation to the Baltic type of figurines a noteworthy amount of times for it to not be a complete coincidence, which I will delve into as this study progresses. The reason that this topic of the figurines as ancestors, and representing an analogy of mortuary body treatment, has not been thoroughly studied in the past is likely because a supposed lack of evidence. This thesis will however provide strong arguments that at least the western type of Baltic figurine in fact represented ancestors. Mortuary rituals regarding missing skeletal elements such as skulls and upper body parts, burials in older cultural layers, package graves as well as secondary burials and scattered bones and ceramics, or even completely empty graves - so called cenotaphs, permeate the Pitted Ware Culture (See Wallin 2017; Lindström 2020; Hed 2021). At Tråsättra, the element of scattered *human* bones are in fact completely absent, whereas at the Ajvide settlement on Gotland, anthropomorphic figurines are equally absent. How come that at one site, one seemingly important element of mortuary ritual (human bones) is non-existent? And at the other, anthropomorphic figurines are nowhere to be found? Can the fragmentation and distribution of the figurines at Tråsättra be compared as an analogy to the scattering of human remains? Many questions, fewer answers.

3. Methodological framework

3.1 Ritual theory

Ritualized behavior has been an integral part of human ontology, mythology and cosmology since the dawn of time; from the most simple and practical task such as making our bed in the morning or brushing our teeth, to the more significant ones such as entering into a marriage or the ceremonial burial of our dead. Some ritualized phenomena are explained and emphasized by literary sources a manyfold, oral history, art and religious scripture - while others are unexplainable, lacking oral history or comprehensible literature to provide researchers with any graspable and/or clear-cut explanation as to *why, when* and *how*. Why did the Neolithic- and Bronze Age people of Scandinavia engrave the bedrock with iconographic elements such as elk, boats, feet, suns and other elements? Why did the inhabitants of Tråsättra and Jettböle manufacture and subsequently destroy clay figurines? Why is red ochre present in mortuary contexts world wide? Ritual theory should be regarded as an analytical tool to study the relationship between human - material - nature. As such, one must also consider the materiality of ritual and how material agency affects human behavior within these ritualized spaces. In this study, ritual is defined by actions that cannot be explained by any mode of requirement. That is, the action was not performed as a requirement to simplify daily life (making ceramic vessels for storage, projectile points for hunting, huts for residing etc.). With that said, it is difficult to decide through our modern lens what "simplified life" for humans 4500 years ago on a metaphysical plane. This fact is also taken into large consideration throughout this thesis. Ritual can further be deemed a patterned and agreed upon activity that exists as a mode of controlling human affairs, and socially sanctioned rules (Verhoeven 2011: 116). Catherine Bell (2009: 16) states as follows, regarding the importance of ritual theory as a research tool - "[...] in each case ritual is seen as a definitive component of the various processes that are deemed to constitute religion, or society, or culture".

3.1.1 Fragmentation of the "soul"?

No one knows what happens when we die. This is the harsh, and for many unacceptable truth that follows us until the day we return to the ground. Humans are seekers, always searching for an answer or an explanation so that she can reconcile herself with what might await in the *after,* and accept that she simply does not know. Prehistoric concepts of death, life and the "soul" can only become graspable by studying mortuary practice and ritual; it was the ritual that connected the divine and the mundane, the ancestors and the living, and the past, present and future. Ritual is in extension what allows the transformation of kin into ancestors, guiding the soul from the body into the next phase of existence (Oestigaard & Kaliff 2020: 40–41, 222–223). Ritual within the Pitted Ware culture is largely manifested through a few variables. First, their mortuary practice consists of ritualistic elements such as intentional fragmentation and dispersal of human and animal remains over seemingly sacred areas or in the cultural layer (see Ajvide burial ground, Alvastra Pile Dwelling, Bollbacken mortuary house). Secondary burials in which an ancestor is exhumed and reburied, and burials in older cultural layers are factors that are often attributed to making the deceased part of the collective memory. The same is true in the case of missing upper body parts such as mandibles and skulls (Larsson 2003: 162; Lindström 2020: 148). In some instances, the body was buried under the floor of a hut of an active settlement (Malmer 2002: 111). Red ochre found in the floor layer of huts or close to living

structures might hint to this type of intimate burial practice. The ritualistic phenomenon of the fragmentation of objects or bones in prehistoric society has often been attributed as giving something or someone a second death, or ending the life-cycle of said object, stripping it of its power. Contrastingly, it can be regarded as a method of tethering it to a new host, a settlement or a place in nature (see Chapman 2000; Fredengren; Björck *et al.* 2020). However, death is an allusive construct. The physical death of a person does not necessarily mean a social death of the "soul". But, what *is* a soul? In Old Norse religion, the concept of a soul did not exist in the same manner as it did when Christianity came to Scandinavia. It had parallels, but the word "soul" was non-existent, even if there were religious constructs essentially synonymous. In the present study, I will nevertheless use the word "soul", since it is the easiest understandable term for what can be best described as the spiritual essence of a living being. Norse cosmology had *Hugr*; "Hugr" is the essence of person, the element that is consciousness as well as subconsciousness and one's inner voice. Hugr can travel between realms and over great distances when the corporal vessel sleeps. In old Norse, there is also a difference between the concept of a *life-force* and the concept of the spirit holding the essence of *you* (hugr, the soul). When you die, your life-force leaves you with your last breath, but the "soul" will not be unbound and ultimately free from the physical body/realm until the dead has undergone the mortuary ritual that finally untetheres the soul from the body - cremation, defleshing, scattering, burial, etc. (Oestigaard & Kaliff 2020: 40–43). Thus, there has been a "fragmentation" between the corporal body, the life force and the "soul". Through this fragmentation, the "soul" can travel into the afterlife, but the afterlife is not necessarily bound to our modern perceptions of heaven or hell. Instead, the afterlife and the ancestor live parallel to those still alive, in the shape of animals, creeks, mountains, objects, within the elements that constitute everything. Therefore, the ancestor is present, agentic and regains "life" and a transformed social status within the metaphysical and liminal realms. Surely, some perception of a soul-like essence must also have existed during the Middle Neolithic of northern Europe, otherwise the mortuary rituals and practices that are so clearly present would be futile.

The topic of fragmentation is ever so present and relevant regarding cultures that are part of the Pit-Comb cultural sphere. The early Neolithic phase of the Comb Ceramic culture, the Typical Comb Ware culture (3900–3500 BC), is often associated with fragmented slate rings, typically found in Finland and somewhat in Estonia. These were mostly made from slate, or metatuff imported from Russian Karelia. The rings were in the majority of cases fragmented into two or more pieces, and although most did not, some had drilled holes or grooves aimed for suspension. These rings have been theorized as part of an enchainment system of gift-giving, but also as protective talismans connected to certain people and/or certain places. Out of the 246 fragments found as of 2022, 19 were found in graves and the remaining part were found in the occupational layers of settlements. Nästinristi and Törmävaara in Finland held very large concentrations in their respective cultural layers, which has been interpreted as intentional depositions at a place that held significance to the group or groups that frequented the location (Ahola 2022: 3–9). Fragmentation is also seen in graves - projectile points, amber pendants, ceramic vessels, and in some rare occasions figurines made from bone or antler. The latter was possibly more established as a tradition than the material record makes light of due to decomposition.

3.1.2 The meaning of ritualized actions

Humans ritualize what is important to them, because why ritualize something that is not of significance? This is the premise this thesis builds upon, that the ritualized action of creation/birth and fragmentation/death simply *must* have meant *something*. Religiously imbued iconographic representation often manifests what was important to the livelihood of said culture. In Scandinavian Pitted Ware culture and Comb Ceramic culture, seals are represented well in the figurine material, either as zoomorphs or seal-human hybrids. Undeniably, the Pitted Ware Culture of Scandinavia is imbued with ritual practice, and especially tangible is the strong

ritualistic and cosmological connection between the humans and the ocean which provides them with their most important source of nutrition and at the same time presents great danger and fear of the vast unknown. This thesis is, however, not centered around the relationship between the Pitted Ware culture and the ocean itself, but it is an unavoidable variable and cannot be dismissed in studying the ritual practices and belief-system of said culture. Prehistoric religion and ritual is often interpreted through what type of religious constellation is deemed most in accordance to the period of time. As Insoll (2011: 1047) explains, the Paleolithic is usually attributed shamanism, and the Neolithic is most commonly said to be the period of growing ancestor cults. It is tied to the development of agriculture, that ancestors empower and bless the land for this newly found sedentary lifestyle. However, that is not to say that the same conceptualization of blessing the land, or hunting ground, can be attributed hunter-gatherers of the Neolithic - but more on that later. To understand a ritualistic space and the humans that are part of said space, one must understand that these parts (i.e the human actor and the non-human actor) constitute a whole. In Deleuze's and Guattari's assemblage theory, Ian Hodder's entanglement theory as well as Bruno Latour's Actor Network theory, the essence lies in understanding that even inanimate things are part of the dynamic *whole* of a place: e.g ceramics, flint axes, post holes, human remains and rock carvings etc., should not be viewed as separate individual finds but should be analyzed as part of a larger social dynamic and as real of a contributor to the cultural structure as any human (see Latour 2005; Hodder 2014; Witmore 2014). Ritual builds man, and man builds ritual; it is reciprocal.

Additionally, building on Bell's previous words - the only way for the archaeologist to find the religious, ritual, social stories of prehistory, we must read between the lines of the material left behind in the archaeological record and hermeneutically, and holistically, analyze these. C. Riley Augé states that ritualistic behaviors are agreed upon actions that hold certain elements, whether it be to enact cultural or religious traditions, or to strengthen the identity of the tribe/community or seeking aid for one's own troubles. Similarly, the survival of traditions requires a collective agreement that the tradition is worth preserving. In this manner one might be able to understand the figurines role as a part of the social interactions between the human and her metaphysical universe, as a possible bridge connecting time and space. In a religious sense, ritual is an integral part of keeping the group united through common practices and shared beliefs, but also recognizing the same cosmological entities and their coexistence with the human realm (Augé 2022: 10–12). Lastly, it is simultaneously equally necessary to be critical of the interpretations of ritual behavior in ancient culture. It is a well-known human fallacy, that if we do not know the answers, our brains tend to wander into the "this must be ritualistic!" room. It is natural, but awareness of this is crucial. With that said, it is of the essence to be open-minded and concurrently critical to ritual and ritual theory. It is the archaeologist's job to get as close to the truth as possible, all the while accepting that the truth might be out of our grasp - how can one prove that something that happened 5000 years ago is because of one thing, and not another?

3.2 Ethnographic analogy

Analogy is the method of conducting research through comparisons between fundamentally different variables and finding similarities between these to explain phenomena (Osta-Vélez & Gärdenfors 2024: 1f). It is an inductive method of placing certain characteristics of what we *do know* of a society, a practice, a function etc., against these characteristics in circumstances that we *do not know* in order to find interpretation. Archaeology would be useless without analogy (Olsen 1997: 70), which is why well thought out ethnographic analogy is crucial. With that said, cultures do not have to be directly or obviously related, or even in close geographical or temporal proximity to each other. Similar economies, belief systems, cosmogonies, ontologies, social structures or technological level, would all suffice in making valid ethnographic analogy (Kaliff 2021: 79). The theoretical premise for the use of ethnographic analogy in this study is

that the cultures and locations chosen for this topic show strong cosmological similarities, which evokes the theory of these cultures developing from a common cultural or cosmological origin. Or, that their similar circumstances created similar religious trajectories. For example, two hunter-gatherer communities existing on either side of the world can develop similar religious practices as they are basically living under the same premises of relying on their entanglement with nature for survival. Building on that, over the last decades figurines of similar figural representation have appeared in concentrations around the European green belt along the coast of the Baltic Sea, and further into eastern Scandinavia (See Loze 1995). This does not *necessarily* mean that they are genetically related, but that these similarities are the result of historical contingencies and circumstances ultimately resulting in similar belief-systems and trajectories of social and religious evolution. A fine example of this is how prehistoric religion in Scandinavia during the Bronze Age evolved from migrating Proto-Indo-European tribes that spread their language and their traditions across Europe, India, Pakistan etc., resulting in the establishing of similar ideologies, cosmogonies and cosmologies across a huge geographical area (Kaliff 2021: 81–83). However, as this thesis will very briefly touch on, it is possible that Proto-Indo-European religion was also influenced by hunter-gatherer cosmologies.

The research for this thesis is heavily centered around ritual theory, materiality and ethnographic and historical analogy. Because, in order to comprehend the ontologies, cosmologies, social- and cultural structures of prehistoric people, one must consider that there is a fundamental universal human experience. All humans, regardless of cultural heritage, historical period, gender, class or geographical location share the same range of emotion, physical needs and mental functions to mostly the same extent. She needs nutrients, water, shelter, companionship, love etc. She grieves, longs and searches for answers to life's mysteries, just as modern humans do. Humans are fundamentally the same over time and space, although identity, culture and such varies. With that said, analogy is certainly not a flawless method; it is circumstantial and can in reality mostly provide qualified hypotheses and more rarely evidence. What it can do, however, is strengthen arguments by proving that certain phenomena has existed or do exist. Simply by providing such proof of something having occurred at some point in time and place, can turn a weak argument into a strong one. When analogizing ritual expression, one must be aware that it can manifest in many forms but essentially be performed for the same purpose, but through different conduits. For example, red ochre presents itself as an element of ritual significance across the world; the Mountain-Ok people of Papua New Guinea hold a strong religious connection to ancestral worship. They receive good hunting fortune, protection and aid in conflict from their ancestors, a phenomenon which is present also in Scandinavia over the long-durée. For them, water constricts the ancestral power and therefore, they smear red ochre over the face and body of the deceased as they believe this protects the dead from the dangerous water (Insoll 2011: 1049). Red ochre is also seen smeared over the face of figurines in Latvia and Finland, and the Tashtyk culture tribes of Siberia created red ochre death masks as part of their mortuary practice (Zaitseva 2009: 423). Red ochre is similarly a common element in graves of the Fennoscandian hunter-gatherers of the Neolithic. Analogy does not have to be exact, what is important is that the compared variables share certain fundamental traits that can aid in the interpretation of a phenomenon. Similarly, comparison and analogy can be drawn between living and inanimate objects. E.g., within the hunter-gatherer societies such as the Chukchi tribe of Siberia, very little human resemblance is needed for something to be humanized and compared to corporal bodies. An amulet made of a piece of leather with the bottom part cut straight in the middle to resemble legs, or the branches of trees resembling arms is just as alive and agential as the human that created it (Bogoras 1907: 278).

Susan Stebbing (1885–1943) discusses how to conduct successful analogy in research in her book “A Modern Introduction to Logic” from 1930. An analogy is only as good as the strength of its argument, Stebbing states - “Its strength depends upon the character of the initial resemblance and upon the relative comprehensiveness of the properties which are asserted to be connected” (1930: 253). Lewis Binford continues Stebbing's discussion from an

archaeological standpoint and provides the example of wear on lithic tools. Binford (1967) addresses similar patterns of wear on end scraper hafts from two separate locations in time and space - North American indigenous people on the one hand, and the late Paleolithic Magdalénien culture on the other. Although these cultures are separate, their basic human needs of food, clothing and shelter were the same; therefore, the analogical hypothesis that these tools were used for the same, or a similar purpose may be justified. With that said, a significant criterion of analogical comparison is that the object of comparison (the function of the scraper of the indigenous people, in this case) is known to be true. Moreover, and as previously mentioned, a large number of cases with a few similarities is not as strong as fewer cases of more similarities (Binford 1967: 2). Two strong arguments of archaeological and ethnographic analogy, as stated by Binfords article, are as follows; The archaeologically observed variable and the ethnographic comparison need to exhibit an accepted continuity in the historical record. And, if the above cannot be established, significant relevance can be given justifiable ground by finding analogies in societies, groups and/or cultures with a similar way of life, ontology and who manipulate their surroundings in a similar manner (Binford 1967: 2, 3).

4. Analysis

4.1 Returning to the soil

4.1.1 Second death and final destruction

Eight graves were discovered at the Tråsättra site, a small number considering the amount of people that inhabited the settlement for over a hundred years. Several of the graves (A1109, A1323, A1249, A11001) had inconspicuous dug-out features on the eastern or southern side of the longer side of the grave pits. They are generally too large to be post holes and are not interpreted as such despite many of the graves being surrounded by post holes. Only one of the dug-out features has got a feature number; A1806 in grave A1323. The other dug out-features were considered part of the graves themselves and therefore not given individual feature numbers. As a rule, in this thesis regarding all sites - feature and ID numbers are given when available. Measurements of the dug-out features were all approx. 0,5–0,8 m in diameter, and 0,2–0,4 m deep (Björck *et al.* 2020: 95–99). It is at this stage not possible to say for certain what these features represent, but one theory is that they display an intentional act of burying, reburying and/or exhuming something in connection to the graves. Although the vast majority of the figurines at Tråsättra were found deposited in the central area of the settlement, we do not know what took place in their *mid-life* stages during the time between their creation and eventual destruction. A mode of explanation can be provided with the following analogy from Siberia. The *Nenets,* an indigenous group of the circum-polar Russian Siberia inhabiting the Kola peninsula and the Taimyr peninsula, exhibit a mortuary ritual that reminds of the Pitted Ware culture figurines of Tråsättra. The Nenets are hunter-gatherer-fishers, displaying a shamanistic religious ideology, where ritualized bodies in the shape of figurines and other objects are central to their mortuary practices. The Nenets use anthropomorphic figurines, "*receptables*" that represent deceased kin, family or members of the community. These "receptables", called "*Sidryang*" ("sidya" meaning two), are manufactured every time a member of the community dies, except for very small children. The face of the figurine is often a button, a piece of wood or a coin while the body is a simple piece of textile. The Sidryang is kept with the family of the deceased for three years; it eats meals with them using miniature bowls and tools, and at large exists as a living, breathing entity. Note that miniature vessels the size of thimbles are also present at Tråsättra. After this three-year period, the Sidryang is finally buried with the carcass of its counterpart. However, after another (undisclosed) period of time, the Sidryang was exhumed from the grave to be destroyed through fire or reburied in a place not too far away from the original grave. Thus, the second and definitive death of this person has been finalized, their "soul" or spirit is finally free, and the community's bond with them has concluded (Khristoforova 2024). As within the Nenet tradition of burying the Sidryang with its counterpart and then exhuming it for its final destruction, a similar tradition might then be visible at the Tråsättra site in regards to these inconspicuous dug-out pits and the figurines. At the Kukkarkoski burial site in western Finland, a small dug-out feature containing red ochre attached to grave 2 contained a deposit of intentionally fragmented flint artefacts, and such deposits are also known from the Zvejnieki cemetery in Latvia. Moreover, in the southern end of grave 2, there was an "empty space" as referred to by Marja Ahola, similar to that of Tråsättra and perhaps representing a votive deposit where something was deposited and then removed (Zagorska 2001: 112–114; Ahola 2015: 32). Of course, there could exist alternative

explanations for these pits. There are, as previously stated, only 8 graves found at Tråsättra. So called “package burials” where the body is bound very tight in a crouching or fetal position so as to fit a smaller space, are known from for example Ajvide on Gotland, Sweden. The bones at Ajvide only covered an area of 0.6x0.6 m in the 1.4x1.4 m pit, and the bones belonged to at least four individuals (Larsson 2009: 269). That is *four* individuals packed in an area of only *0.6x0.6 m*, so it would definitely be possible to achieve packing at least two individuals in the dug-out pits of Tråsättra. If this was the case, it could be a matter of burying kin next to an already deceased family member, moving the decomposed bones to make room for a new body. Burying kin with kin at Pitted Ware culture burial sites has recently been proven by archaeogenetic analysis at Ajvide (see Mattila *et al.* 2026).

Travelling to an entirely different part of the world; at the Mixteca Alta village of Oaxaca, Mexico, 3000 year old burned clay figurines show parallels in body treatment to deceased community members. In the Mesoamerican Formative Period (1500 BC–200 AD), the intentional breaking and depositing of material objects (figurines, pottery, jade, sculptures etc.) perceived as alive was part of a mortuary process of ending its life-cycle and ability to affect the community. This fragmentation was mainly performed when the owner of said object passed away. Burials of this site, for example burial 3 in Excavation 1, displayed an abundance of disarticulated and commingled human remains. Interpretations usually orbit around this being the result of recurring visits to the burial in order to retrieve remains for rituals, or secondary burials. At the Tayata settlement, also in Oaxaca, figurines have been treated in parallel to the human corpus. Fragmentation and burning patterns, as well as depositioning patterns reveal a symbolic relationship between non-human and human agents. This Mesoamerican cultural practice showed that the process of birthing objects and their subsequent destruction was analogous to the life-cycle of living entities, as a metamorphosis between different levels of existence (Meissner *et al*. 2013: 7, 13, 26–32).

4.1.2 Local adaptations to Pitted Ware culture ritual practice - Tråsättra, Ajvide and Jettböle

There are no human remains found at Tråsättra, but nonetheless, phosphate analysis of the supposed graves displays elevated values revealing that humans were most likely put to rest there. Many times, even if the preservative conditions are not optimal, the altered chemistry in the settlement layers from decaying organic refuse would allow some traces of human remains to linger. This explains why there are remains of animal bones, both burnt (67 %) and unburnt, in the occupational layer of the central area in Tråsättra. However, even the seemingly unburnt bones might be affected by heat of lower temperatures, making the amount of burnt bones possibly significantly higher or even fully encompassing (Björck *et al.* 2020: 169). Cremated bones last considerably longer in the soil, and would - if one were to base this statement solely on inductive observations of other Pitted Ware culture sites - also be present at Tråsättra. So, how does one explain then, that there is an absolute absence of human remains at the site? Comparison can be drawn to both Ajvide on Gotland, and Jettböle I on Åland. Gotlands’ as well as Ålands’ soil is calcareous and therefore provides fitting preservational conditions for organic remains. At both sites, scattered human remains are present both in the settlement layers but also around the graves themselves. At Ajvide, the circumstances regarding human remains and clay figurines is the complete opposite of that of mainland Tråsättre where there instead are a large amount of figurines but no human bones. The explanation can lie in a local adaptation of a wider tradition seen within the Pitted Ware culture. Prehistoric humans were not less smart than modern humans; they simply operated under different circumstances. Arguably, they would have had some sense of the preservational qualities, or lack thereof, of the soil around them. Of course, this would have been knowledge passed through generations, as it can take up to ten years or more for bones to go through diagenesis (Vass 2010. Accessed 19/2/2026). Let me explain - it is unknown from where this specific group originated, as no bones remain to conduct, for instance, strontium-isotope analysis, to see where the oldest generation of the

settlement wandered in from. Recent ICP-MA/ES analysis of 19 potsherds and 39 figurines can however reveal that the clay from ten of the anthropomorphs were sourced from Åby in Norrköping, Sweden, Norvik in Södermanland, Sweden, Ajvide on Gotland, Sweden and Åland, Finland (Fauvelle *et al.* 2025: 6). If the founders of the Tråsättra settlement migrated from, or came in contact with the Gotland population, the scattering of the fragmented figurines in the settlement layer would possibly depict said local adaptation to their circumstances. This would be supported also by the absence of figurines at Ajvide - they did not need to adapt this tradition, as their bones did not decay in the same manner. The relevant period of this thesis 2525–2480 BC, and phase three of the Ajvide settlement 2600–2300 BC, which is the phase where archaeology can trace an increased ritual activity with the scattering of human remains at Ajvide, coincide nicely (Wallin 2017: 118). The hypothesis could be supported by the ICP-MA/ES analysis of clay provenance just mentioned, positing the idea that they traveled from Tråsättra to Gotland some time during that time span for cultural exchange, seasonal gatherings or trade. Then perhaps the figurines of Tråsättra could represent ancestors through a different media, where the fragmentation and deposition in the occupational layer is an analogy to the scattering of human remains at Ajvide on Gotland.

I would further like to suggest another similar explanation to the above mentioned, however with some modification - instead placing focus on Jettböle as a major influence of the Tråsättra group. One cannot neglect the fact that recent research has revealed that the Gotlandic Pitted Ware culture groups were very sedentary and did not, from what can be established thus far, intermix with populations from the mainland to any significant extent (Coutinho *et al.* 2020: 1–10). For example, strontium isotope analysis of the Västerbjers Pitted Ware culture population revealed that the group kept local and did predominantly only traverse around the island as well as into the Baltic Sea for fishing (Boethius *et al*. 2024: 3). Still, a few figurines found at Tråsättra showed provenance to Gotland and Åland. Strontium isotope analysis from Jettböle showed that there is a likelihood that a selected few from the Jettböle population likely travelled to Öland, eastern Gotland (Västerbjärs) and the southeastern Swedish mainland (Boethenius *et al*. 2024: 1–10), likely for seasonal hunting rituals, feasting, cultural, social and/or religious exchange. So, a similar but modified explanation is that the influence of scattered human remains (or figurines) in the occupational layer as an act of binding ancestors to a place, could still be largely inspired from Gotland - but as a *by-proxy* influence channeled through Jettböle on Åland. It is already obvious and established that there were contacts between Tråsättra and the Åland Islands, as there is no denying the similarities of the figurines of both sites, especially not considering the ICP-MA/ES results mentioned above. Could it be possible that the figurines seemingly from Gotland, were created by seafarers from Jettböle, temporarily visiting the island (Gotland) and subsequently bringing the figurines to Tråsättra during seasonal travels? Before this paragraph becomes too wordy, one final take on the matter is that it might also be possible that the ideology of scattered human bones in settlement layers came from Jettböle, was brought to Gotland and also to Tråsättra, as the tradition started earlier there during the Jettböle I phase 3350–2600 BC (Lucenius 2021: 127)

4.1.3 Alloforms - Bodies of clay

This chapter explores whether the Tråsättra figurines can represent early conceptualizations of alloforms - embodied life that is created/birthed and ritually destroyed/killed at the end of its life-cycle. The idea of alloforms is that every entity in the world is created from the same basic components of the cosmos - water, fire, earth and wind. Meat is earth/soil, bones are rocks and mountains, blood is water, and so forth - this schema can be discerned in early Proto Indo-European religion. In Norse cosmogony/Snorri Sturlassons *Gylfaginning* from the Poetic Edda it is Odin, Vili and Ve killing the ice giant Ymir;

> They took Ymir and carried him into the middle of Ginnungagap and made the world from him: from his blood the sea and lakes, from his flesh the earth, from his bones the

> mountains; rocks and pebbles they made from his teeth and jaws and those bones that were broken (Lincoln 1975: 127).

In the Indo-Iranian scripture of the *Avesta,* the myth is about the primordial being *Gayomard* and the hermaphrodite *sole-created Ox,* where upon their deaths fifty-five species of corn and twelve medicinal herbs were created, and from the semen of the Ox cattle and other animals were birthed. From Gayomards body came also tin, silver, gold, copper and iron (Lincoln 1975: 125–128; West 2007: 35; Kaliff 2025: 50). Creating a figurine of clay requires all of the four basic elements - earth and water to create a malleable corporal clay body, and air and fire to achieve its hardened final transformation. In receiving its final and finished state, it has been birthed in the same way as every living being in the world and is thus perceived as such. The subsequent destruction of the figurines, which in "life" would have represented a specific human, would then represent the same death as its counterpart. We see this fragmentation in not only figurines, but also in the scattering of human and animal remains in burial sites and settlements, acting as the final sacrifice of returning to the four elements and becoming chained to a specific important place for the group/tribe/community (Kaliff 2007: 149, 154). In the Scandinavian Bronze- and Iron Ages, bones - cremated or not cremated - were seen as fortifying the soil with the power of creation and fertility, and in extension as "altars". The same goes for bones found in contexts outside of graves, such as occupational layers of settlements, or as votive deposits in post-holes or other inconspicuous pits in or close to settlements.

Although the above referenced Anders Kaliff discusses altars in relation to fertility in agriculture, the same basic idea can be applied to offerings for good hunting fortune within hunter-gatherer communities. Offerings, or sacrifices of human and animal bones in buildings are known from Neolithic times, such as the Pitted Ware culture mortuary house of Bollbacken, Västmanland, as well as the Battle Axe culture/third group mortuary house of Turinge, Södermanland. At these settlements, pits of cremated human bones as well as some animal bones and a fair amount of pottery were buried in pits inside and/or on the outside, adjacent to the house. At Turinge, the bones of at least eight individuals had different parts of their bones deposited in different pits, whereas at least one was a very small infant. In the same location, four intact pottery vessels were found whereas one vessel was placed inside another vessel with the same type of decoration. If clay were to represent alloforms, indivisible from humans, this could be interpreted as perhaps a mother and her infant (Larsson 2009: 284–289). The schema of sacrificial fragmentation as well as alloforms and the transfer of life-energy can be backtracked to the Pit-Comb cultural sphere; the Comb Ceramic culture placed fragmented projectile points in deposits and covered them with red ochre (see below for ritual implementations of red ochre), and a common variable Pitted Ware culture cosmology is the practice of ritual dismemberment and scattering of human- and animal bones in sacral place, such as the "seal-altar" of Ajvide, or the commingled human remains from older generations in the younger gravefield of Zvejnieki, Latvia. Besides, the Geta settlement on Åland reveals that the fragmentation of the figurines was purposeful and done with a cause. The fact that one of the figurines at Geta had been mended with tree sap upon being accidentally broken before its intended destruction, further proves that they existed for a reason (Fast & Soisalo 2024: 13–14). At the Jägala Jõesuu V Stone age settlement in Estonia dated to 3200-3100 BC, 91 figurine fragments of anthropomorphic and zoomorphic nature were excavated. 57 % of them were deposited in the bottom layers of a pit house, whereas all of the anthropomorphs of the site were found in the same house (Khrustaleva 2020: 2–14). A disclaimer is however needed regarding this site; it is very hard to discern the shapes of these figurines, and it is impossible to say if they are of the eastern, western or mixed type. The site is dated to 3200–3100 BC, which would make the western or mixed type more likely.

The above-mentioned ritual acts are, as mentioned, typical to Proto-Indo-European religion. It is reasonable to explore the possibility of this particular aspect of Proto-Indo-European religious practice as being an influence from hunter-gatherer ideologies. After all, there were large migrations in the Late Neolithic, leading to cultural transmissions, from Scandinavia and central Europe, stretching eastwards and reaching the steppes beyond the Ural

Mountains (Kaliff 2007: 38–39). Additionally, trading networks along rivers, the Baltic coast and inland bodies of water created a nexus of cross-regional sea- and wayfaring, connecting the Baltic Sea with Fennoscandian shores, Northern Russia and the North European Plain (Elliott *et al*. 2021: 707). Ideas, traditions and cultural practices were deemed to intermix. The Corded Ware culture, widely considered a precursor of early Proto-Indo-European, did interact with the Pit-Comb sphere of Fennoscandia at the end of the 3rd millenia – early Bronze Age. Partly through Battle Axe culture, but if one were to humor this suggestion, a more reasonable trajectory would be through the Volosovo culture of the Volga-Kama region of Central Russia. There is not enough space in this thesis to do a full exploration of the subject, but archaeology can trace interactions and similarities between Fennoscandian Comb Ceramic culture, Pitted Ware culture and the Volosovo culture (see Ahola 2015: 23–30) - a culture that in fact was assimilated into the Corded Ware culture Fatyanovo culture going into the Bronze Age (Nordqvist & Heyd 2020: 72). Moreover, creating man from clay is certainly not exclusive to prehistoric Scandinavia or (Proto)Indo-European religion. In Hebrew, the name "Adam" (*Adamah*) means red soil/red clay and tracks back to how God created man from clay. In the same chapter of the Book of Genesis 2:7 it is written "*Now out of the ground the Lord God had formed every beast of the field and every bird of the heavens*". In the Babylonian genesis story, the goddess Mami, the god Enki and other deities create humankind from clay mixed with the blood from a slain god (Heidel 1951: 97). The *"golem"* of Judaism is a human-like entity solely animated and brought to life through malleable clay and soil (Reed 2022). In ancient Egyptian mythology, the god Khnum created human children from clay and placed them in the wombs of mothers (O.G. Silva 2020: 186). The same theme continues into Africa, the Near East, Japan, China, and so forth. Although research cannot yet prove that the same conceptualization of the creation of humans existed regarding the figurines at Tråsättra, it is certainly strong proof that such ideas and cosmologies have been particularly common throughout history. Possibly then, humans saw themselves as part of the earth, that themselves as well as everything around them came from the same soil, and in the same manner everything would return to the same soil after the physical death. "From Dust to Dust", as they say.

4.2 Ritual body treatment of the figurines

4.2.1 Bodies wrapped in skin and plastered death masks

A. Wrapped bodies

The figurines of Tråsättra, as well as the western type figurines in general, do not have defined limbs. This fact, in combination with the patterns on their drop shaped bodies evokes the idea of recreating a wrapped corpse. The idea has been proposed in passing-by, by archaeologist and professor Liv Nilsson Stutz, but it has not been examined further in specific regards to the western type of figurine seen at Tråsättra, Jettböle, Gipka-Purciems, etc. (2006: 232). The idea of wrapping bodies as part of preparing the deceased for burial is represented in various temporal and spatial scales - for instance, the Iglulirmiut inuit people of Canada wrap their deceased kin in deer skin (Boas 1888: 613), and the same tradition can be spotted within the Greenlandic Thule culture, as evident by the "mummies" from the period somewhere between 1200–1700AD, found in the 20th century (Lynnerup 2015). Similar practices can be discerned at the Mesolithic burial sites of Henriksholm-Bøgebakken in Denmark and the Mesolithic/Neolithic Comb Ceramic culture burial ground at Zvejnieki in Northern Latvia, where excavation found tooth pendants that were supposedly tied to the shroud of animal skin or other organic material that wrapped the deceased (Grünberg 2013: 232). In Sweden, mentions of possible body-wrappings are scarce. In Gunborg Janzons dissertation "Gotlands

mellanneolitiska gravar" from 1974, she mentions the presence of swine-hoofs underneath or close to the body of the deceased in four graves at the Ire burial ground on Gotland. Janzon suggests that the hoofs are possible remnants of a wrapping made of animal skin, but she does not elaborate on this further. Göran Burenhult likewise suggests the possibility of a wrapped, or "tied", body in grave no. 4 at the Ajvide burial site, where the legs were crossed as if they were originally bound together (2002: 45). Osteological remains from seals in grave 6 at Ire suggests the presence of seal skin wrapping. Also at Ire, red ochre has been present in cases where swine-hoofs were included in the grave material. Red ochre has also been found in graves at Hangvar and Visby on Gotland, close to the heads and covering the bodies. At Visby, the body of a 12-year old was completely covered in red ochre, and grave 14 belonging to a 20-year-old woman had patches of red ochre (Janzon 1974: 21-22, 108). At the Ajvide site on Gotland, grave 79 AB containing two individuals – a child about 8 years old and a woman around 18 years old -, contained a large chunk of yellow ochre which had a seal tooth attached to it (Norderäng 2007: 10). Also at Ajvide, in graves no. 2, 5, 6, 9, 13, 23, 38, 45, 48, 63, 66, 70, 73, and 79 there are mentions of red ochre, yellow ochre, ochre or simply "red shaded soil" (Burenhult 2002: 31–49, 91–108; data on graves 63, 66, 70, and 73 were obtained from an unpublished Microsoft Access database compiled by Johan Norderäng). Where in the grave these finds of ochre were situated is not specified.

Hunter-gatherer groups of the lithic periods heavily relied on and were affected by their surrounding nature and dependency on good hunting fortune, which in turn created a complex entanglement with said factors. Wrapping deceased kin in animal furs or skin would then be an act of transmission and transformation, merging the ancestor with the spirit of the animal. Marek Zvelebil, a Czech-Dutch archaeologist, suggested a continuity of Mesolithic cosmological beliefs from North Eurasian hunter-gatherers surviving in modern indigenous cultures, such as the *Kets* of western Siberia, that still abide by these standards. These beliefs can be, in short, summarized as follows; the soul of an individual is both human and animal, certain animals are mediators between the living world and the afterlife, nature is a providing element that needs to be respected in order to keep providing, to name a few. The importance of animals is also represented in Neolithic rock art of Nämforsen in Sweden, showcasing how the elk epitomized a central figure in prehistoric cosmology (Zvelebil 1997: 33–50; Conneller 2012: 365). In Northern Europe, 52 zoomorphic stone axes or maces depicting bear- or elk heads have been found, predominantly in Finland and Russia (Mantere & Kashina 2022: 36). At the Neolithic Lyalovo (5000–3650 BC) and Volosovo burial ground Saktysh IIa in Central Russia, zoomorphic figurines depicting bears display a totemistic practice where bears are held in high regard. The Lyalovo phase of the burial ground showed signs of wrapped burials from needles and pins, supposedly having been used to secure the skin wrapped around the dead. Moreover, at the same burial ground a "mask" made of elkhorn was found and similar motives have been found at the Tamula site in Estonia, Abora in Latvia and Usvyaty in Russia (Kostyleva 2018: 299–303). This intricate relationship with animals, and especially seals, is represented at both Tråsättra, where 744 of the 1673 animal bone fragments were from seals, as well as Ajvide on Gotland and Jettböle on Åland. The *Käutaltare* (seal altar, a place for the slaughtering of seals) of Ajvide was drenched with seal oil, scattered with human remains, ceramics and flint (Österholm 2010: 367). At Jettböle II, unburnt human bones were found in close relation to a deposition of seal skulls, in the same trench as all of the figurine fragments - not to mention the 16 500 potsherds of FA IVb type (Stenbäck 2003: 127–128, 165–169). The point that is being argued here, is that if the figurines depict bodies perhaps wrapped in seal skin, it would make sense why, for example Jan Storå, in 2001 interpreted them as seal-humans (Storå 2001: 49–51). An analogy can be drawn to the Central Inuit cultures of North America; during seal hunting, the hunters dressed up in sealskins to blend in with unsuspecting seals, according to the ethnographic study "The Central Eskimo" conducted by Franz Boaz in 1888 (Boaz 1888: 484). Similarly, for the Netsilik inuit groups of Greenland, there are spirits called "*to'tal'et"* representing "seal-men", originating from local mythology that a mother wrapped her newborn infant in sealskin and taught it to swim as well as a seal (Rasmussen 1931: 247).

Also, the Alta Neolithic rock carvings in Finnmark, Northern Norway show this metamorphosis of humans and animals. For these groups, the reindeer was especially important and central to their economy as well as their ontology. One scene suggests how a hunter flies over the sky and turns into the very reindeer being hunted. It could be suggested that similar practices and beliefs may have occurred amongst the hunters of Tråsättra and other cultures of the Pit-Comb cultural sphere.

It is further worth mentioning that in Finland, in a number of cases whenever a wrapped body is suspected in Comb Ceramic culture graves, large amounts of red ochre is present. It has been suggested that the wrapping itself was heavily strewn with ochre as a part of the ritual handling of the body (Ahola 2015: 27). The so-called "Paimio-idols" found in Paimio parish in Finland, which is considered to be an early form of the western type figurine, display traces of being painted with red ochre in a fairly large but undisclosed number of cases (Nũnez 1986: 19). Some of the Paimio-idols ornamentation strongly resemble a body being wrapped with straps across the back and torso (fig. 8). In Latvia, in the Gipka-Purciems sand dunes of Northern Kurzeme at the settlement of Gipka A, massive amounts of red ochre was found dispersed in various features. It was found in a vessel underneath a thick layer of soot and red ochre by a central hearth, next to a three-walled palisade or fence construction. In a posthole located to the construction's western side, a figurine fragment of the western type was found with its face smeared in red ochre (See Loze 2005 fig. 6), while the bottom of the figurine was found in a post hole next to it. In the central hearth archeologists found the bust of a figurine that had been intentionally burnt, apart from the burning in the manufacturing process. Ilze Loze interpreted the 20-something figurines at the settlement as ancestors from different generations, that aided the living but could be equally malicious if mistreated (Loze 2005: 156–162; Loze 2008: 53). Red ochre as a life-giving element, and as a particular sort of alloform, is seen all around the world. It is the universal element used in cultures worldwide to represent extended life and life-giving blood. Red ochre was not produced on a whim; it required knowledge and prowess passed through generations. Finding suitable mineral quarries *i.e* streams, bogs, lakes etc., dehydrating it and subsequently burning it at 300-500 degrees to achieve its bright red color is a time consuming task (Zagorska 2008: 115–117) and would not be done without cause. In this sense, it can be regarded as a transgressional element and alloform, representing fire/warmth, life/blood and in being sourced from the soil, it can represent the earth itself. Additionally, one cannot forget that the blood and bleeding of women i.e menstruation, or the absence thereof upon fertilization, is strongly connected to creating life - adding another example of "life-giving blood" that must have affected prehistoric spirituality. Below, the connections between body treatment, figurines and red ochre will continue.

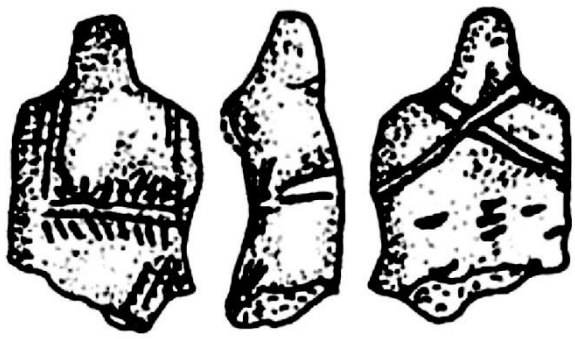


Figure 8. "Paimio-idol". Photo: Nũnez 1986: 19.

B. Plastered death masks

The western type figurine has a peculiar face - in many cases, they are facing the sky as if they are adorning the sun, or staring back at whoever unearths them. Or perhaps they are staring back at their creators, as to communicate with them. They are often sculpted to transgress the human-animal dichotomy, although as of late, the anthropomorphic interpretation has gained more attention. The patterns on the faces are nearly always dotted lines, reaching from the forehead down over the nosebridge, and/or tracing the chin downwards and to the sides to reach the jaw. Theories regarding facial tattoos similar to that of the inuit *Kakiniit* have been discussed, but as of yet, no proof or traces of a tattooing practice can be discerned within the Pitted Ware culture, at any known locale. This could of course be due to the perishable nature of, for example, bone awls or needles used for tattooing. Vessels with remains of red ochre pigment have been interpreted as remains from the processing and manufacture of the substance, or as part of the tradition of staining grave goods. The markings could also be faces painted with charcoal for certain rites or ceremonies, or wooden masks utilized in shamanistic rituals. Here however, another theory will be examined - clay and ochre plastered death masks.

Death masks are rarely discussed in North European Neolithic contexts - simply because it is a rare occurrence and not much is known about it, providing all the more reason to include it in the archaeological discourse. Clay death masks are known from the late Iron Age Tashyk culture of Russia (Zaitseva 2009: 423), it is also known from Neolithic Tepecik-Çiftlik and Catalhöyuk, Central Anatolia, where they have been interpreted as a cog in the mechanism of ancestral worship (Büyükkarakaya *et al*. 2024: 3). The list goes on - the point is that it has been an established practice crossing temporal as well as spatial scales. The practice of applying clay masks to the deceased in the eastern Baltic area came about in the beginning of the 4th century BC, and is attributed to the Typical Comb Ware filiation of the Comb Ceramic culture. Unburnt clay, sometimes mixed with red ochre, is placed over the face of the corpse along with amber rings or discs as well as animal teeth covering the eyes orifices. The clay being unburnt makes it more difficult to identify masks, as unburnt clay rarely stays in its manipulated shape over time. Placing amber on the masks as substitution for eyes, can be seen clearly in at least five Middle Neolithic graves at the Zvejnieki Comb Ceramic culture cemetery in Latvia, as well as in two graves at Hartikka, one grave in Kolmahaara and one in Pispa in Finland. However, several similar graves with remains of clay masks lacking amber exist across Latvia and Finland, suggesting that the tradition may have existed in variations, possibly due to local practices and circumstances (Zagorska 2001: 112; Elliott *et al.* 2021: 708–710). The practice has also been observed somewhat in the Lake Onega region of northwest Russia, at the Late Neolithic Volosovo site of Tudozero VI, where amber rings were found in pairs covering the area of where the eyes would have been (Oshibkina 2001: 138) - a typical tell sign for some sort of death mask in the Baltic Neolithic context. In the double grave 316/317 at Zvejnieki holding one male and one female between 20-40 years old, massive amounts of red ochre was strewn over the face and anterior cervical vertebrae of the male, which has been interpreted as remains of a death mask. This skeleton also shows signs of having been wrapped tightly before burial, most likely in animal skin (Elliott *et al.* 2021: 713–715). Similar circumstances are represented at the Hartikka Comb Ceramic culture cemetery in Finland in graves 3 and 7, where tooth enamel was found where the ochre was at its thickest - suggesting the possible position of a plastered skull (Ahola 2015: 26). However, ochre is usually only present in the minority of cases regarding plastered skulls, as only three out of the 15 cases in Latvia and Finland have ochre mixed in with the clay (Elliott *et al*. 2020: 710). In Sweden, plastered death masks are not explicitly mentioned in research. But, I would like to argue for their existence by mentioning a few cases of clay and ochre in Pitted Ware culture graves on Gotland. At the Ire/Hangvar burial ground, in grave nr. 4, red ochre was found over the crania of a male approx. 40-50 years old. In the same grave there were grave goods in the shape of bird bones, swine hoofs and varying small fish bones. In the collective grave nr. 6 of Ire, whereas three individuals were buried (an adult man, a younger boy and a woman around 18 years old). Slightly above the forehead of the 18-year-old woman was a lump of yellow ochre mixed with clay. This “lump”

of ochre and clay was rectangularly rounded. At the Visby grave field, in grave 6 belonging to a woman between 30-40 years old, intense red ochre was found directly in relation to the crania. In grave 8 at the Visby grave field, red ochre was found directly in relation to the crania of a four-year-old child (Janzon 1974: 108). Janzon mentions, that under the knee of a man buried with red ochre, there was a "clay animal head" that has since been lost from the archives. Janzon never mentions anything about these inclusions of ochre being remnants of death masks, but that does not make it any less likely. It has been a long time since these graves were excavated, and the idea of plastered death masks might simply not have crossed her mind. It is possible that the research of such things in neighboring countries did not exist yet in the 70´s either, providing no point of reference to begin thinking in such trajectories.

That plastered skulls/death masks existed both with and without ochre, as well as with and without ornaments (Ahola 2017: 209), could suggest that the figurines of Tråsättra might depict such masks despite the absence of ochre-covering. Simultaneously and as a fitting comparison, only a small amount of the western type of figurine have their faces covered in red ochre. At the ceremonial Gipka A site in Latvia, at least one figurine had its face distinctly covered in red ochre. Ilze Loze suggests that several of the clay figurines of Gipka-Purciems had their bodies or faces covered in red ochre as to reanimate the figurines before breaking them and giving them a final death. On mainland Finland, as well as on the Finnish Åland island at the Jettböle site, an undisclosed number of fragmented figurines had their faces and/or bodies covered in red ochre (Nunẽz 1986: 18– 22). Masks can function as a divide between the mundane and the divine (Elliott *et al*. 2020: 711), and in this sense, placing a mask on the deceased could represent a new social status. Giving the corpse a new identity and function as an ancestor whose "soul" is no longer tethered to the corporal body. This transmission can be traced not only in the use of death masks within the Comb Ceramic culture, but also in the manufacturing and use of clay figurines. As previously mentioned, the tradition of figurine manufacturing and the following destruction is a reproduction of a cosmology well documented within the Comb Ceramic culture. It is plausible that other traditions were also transmitted into the Pitted Ware culture cosmology - such as plastered death masks. There is further a significant change in the manufacture and treatment of the eastern and western type of figurines. I cannot say that the eastern "bean shaped" type resembles wrapped bodies or plastered death masks. Thus, there seems to have been a cosmological turn at around 3300–3000 BC, when the Typical Comb Ware branched off into local traditions of the younger Comb Ceramic culture and the intrinsic meaning of the figurines changed. The dawn of the western type figurine *de facto* aligns well with the dawn of the Pitted Ware culture, suggesting that this type of figurine represents a ritual- and religious transmission and mixture of Comb Ceramic culture and Pitted Ware culture traditions. So, originally the eastern figurines might not have been manufactured for the same purpose that the western figurines eventually were.

5. Discussion and result

It is fair to say that certain practices in regards to life and death are, and have been, common ritual elements transgressing spatial and temporal boundaries. Treating corporal bodies of meat and bones parallel to the treatment of non-human entities displays a type of animism that dismisses human exceptionalism, and places non-human agency not as lesser than, but as equal to that of humans. The *to'tal'et* "seal-men" of the Netsilik inuits, the Mixteca figurines being treated as equals to humans, or weapons of the Iron Age being ritually killed beside their owner; all are examples, or analogies, showing that the dichotomy of animate - inanimate and alive - dead is continuously blurry. That the hunter gatherers of Tråsättra, and in extension those of the Baltic Sea coastline, abided by a cosmology that placed nature and all of its fundamental elements at its core is further evident. Zvelebil's research on the Mesolithic way of life continuing over great timespans can further explain how the Neolithic people of Tråsättra viewed their relationship with their surroundings. Applying great reverence towards the animals that feed them and essentially is keeping the whole settlement alive must have affected them greatly. An ancestral reverence can further be equally applied to the landscape itself, having created a life there and being connected to a place where generations of kin have existed. Not only in the form of flesh and blood, but as a spiritual presence perhaps manifested through the figurines. In regards to wrapping the deceased in animal skins, merging the power of the animal with the ancestor would then allow the ancestor to bring power and fortune to the settlement. I would argue that the drop-shaped form of the figurines, in addition with their patterns resembling clothes and cross-wrappings - especially prevalent in the Paimio-idols speak in favor of this hypothesis. This, in addition with the fact that red ochre is almost always present in wrapped burials of the closely related Comb Ceramic culture, strengthens the theory. Bodies wrapped in animal skin has been, as mentioned earlier, loosely discussed in the Swedish material by Gunborg Janzon (1974), in the case of a few graves at Ire on Gotland. If this is correct, the possibility of it occurring also in graves on mainland Sweden (i.e Tråsättra) becomes far more plausible. That Ajvide presents no red ochre or traces of wrapped burials or plastered death masks might then display a local tradition that separated itself from other Pitted Ware culture groups. It is also possible that when studying the burials of Ajvide, traces of these practices might have been interpreted as something else.

Ajvide separates itself from mainland Pitted Ware culture in at least one important manner; the tradition of figurine manufacture is practically non-existent there, as mentioned previously. The people of Gotland seemingly did not intermix with the Comb Ceramic culture during the time of this tradition, thus, since the Comb Ceramic culture was the main influence of figurine manufacture and use, this might explain the absence thereof. The same argument is difficult to apply regarding the plastered masks, but nonetheless, the faces of the figurines do represent *something*. They most certainly do not represent a "normal" human head or face - they knew what heads looked like and surely they knew how to shape the clay into a more life-like rounder shape. Instead, they consciously chose to shape them into something more inconspicuous, something that was transcending boundaries. Death masks of the Neolithic Baltic likely served the same purpose, being a liminal object that transformed one thing into another. Closing the door to one realm of existence and opening the door to the next realm. I would further like to argue that the few cases of red- and yellow ochre over the crania or very close to it in graves at Ire/Hangvar and Visby on Gotland, also strengthens the argument for the existence of death masks in Sweden. Although it is possible that ochre stains occurred in these graves due to other reasons such as water seepage, or the decay of containers made from organic material holding

ochre. The inclusion of yellow ochre in grave 79 AB at the Ajvide burial ground *could* represent some kind of mask, but its haphazard occurrence in, seemingly, one single grave is an inconclusive argument for death masks at Ajvide specifically, in regard to it being only one out of 85 graves. It is also unclear if yellow ochre inhabited the same significance as red ochre, making this specific inclusion of ochre all the more difficult to interpret in relation to Pitted Ware culture cosmology and ritual life. Regarding the other inclusions of red ochre, yellow ochre and "red stained soil" at the Ajvide burial site, it is complicated to analyze its role in Pitted Ware mortuary practices without more detail of where in the burial it was found. The literature simply elucidates that it was present, excluding important information such as if it was found by the head, the pelvis, the entire body, or covering the burial gifts, etc. Yet, it does prove that the use of ochre in mortuary practice was in fact present at Ajvide as well, and as stated previously - ochre was not created on a whim, it had purpose.

Moreover, one cannot ignore the fact that no matter *when* we exist, there is a fundamental human experience. Even today, when a loved one dies it is common to keep memorabilia of the dead, or to bury them with tokens that represent the relationships they had in life. In a time with no photos to keep of the dead person, memorabilia must have been created through other media. The figurines might represent such a medium, representing a memory of the deceased while also representing their elevated social status as a powerful ancestor having returned to the "origin of everything". Finally breaking them and depositing them in the soil of the settlement would then represent the final stage of enchaining the ancestor to the settlement, and thus eternalizing them for generations to come. After all, as mentioned several times in this thesis; scattering human remains in the settlement layer and burial sites was an integral part of Pitted Ware culture mortuary ritual. What archeology can discern, however, is that the figurines were not to be broken before their use-phase was over. Drawing from the example of the figurine from Geta on Åland that had seemingly been mended after having been accidentally broken, it reveals a glimpse of the mid-life use of the figurines that is very difficult to observe under most circumstances. This proves that they did have a purpose in remaining intact for a certain amount of time, and were not simply created just to be broken instantly. It mattered if they broke before they were intended to - why mend something just to break it again at a later stage, if it was not for a purpose? Much like the example of the Nenet "Sidryang" receptables, the figurines were created, kept intact/alive for an unknown period of time, and subsequently broken and deposited close to graves. The Geta settlement on Åland might represent such a location, where a "final death" took place, and the same can be said about the Käut-altare at Ajvide as well as the central area of Tråsättra. In chapter 3.2 "Ethnographic analogy", it was mentioned that very little human resemblance is needed for something to be perceived as alive according to the Siberian Chukchee religion. Likewise, when children play with toys they apply a certain agency to them, making them "alive" for the purpose of the act. Although I do not believe the figurines were toys, it shows how easy and natural it is to perceive something as alive.

There is also a need to discuss the find-location of the figurines, concentrated in the central area of the settlement. One might think that all actions and practices related to burials and mortuary practices must occur in close proximity to the grave - this is incorrect. Practices related to mortuary traditions need not be restricted to the location of the graves. The figurines are to the majority not found in the graves and can therefore be seen as part of a mortuary practice that served a better purpose outside away from its corporeal counterpart. If the fragmentation of the figurines is equal to the fragmentation of humans, then the scattering of these can be considered equal to the tradition of depositing human remains in the settlement layer. Thus making this tradition part of a mortuary practice that is acted out away from the grave. A burial ritual is not one single action, or restricted to one single location. The rituals can hold several steps that happen away from the grave and the deceased, such as feasting, sacrifices, and processions. Mortuary rituals can additionally occur before the burial in preparing the body and through memorial wakes. Also after the individual has been put to rest in the ground, acts related to the death of a loved one can continue for an indefinite amount of time through mourning practices and ceremonies. Dismissing the figurines as part of a mortuary process simply because

they are not found in the graves is therefore not a valid argument. Instead, I would like to argue that the questions of this thesis have found support in the analysis of the varying historical- and ethnographic analogies provided.

5.1 Future research opportunities

Going forward, the research regarding fragmentation and the concept of alloforms within Proto-Indo-European can with an advantage be sought within the Pit-Comb cultural horizon. Clay figurines as alloforms is at its core a phenomena that has time and again been proven to be a staple of (pre)historical ontologies. During the Middle Neolithic and towards the end of the 3rd millennia BC, there was a cultural- and ritual transmission between cultures of the Corded Ware complex and North European and Eurasian hunter-gatherers. Not only through burial practices such as mixed Corded Ware culture and Pitted Ware culture graves, but also through import and export of skillsets, artifacts and other goods. This vast network fortified the basis that the great Bronze Age contact- and trade networks were built upon, and it also allowed the dispersal of new cosmologies and belief systems. I think that there is a lot of potential in studying how the hunter-gatherer cosmology of the middle-late Neolithic affected the birth of Proto-Indo-European religion. It might aid in filling some of the gaps in the research of where certain aspects of Proto-Indo-European religion originate. After all, fragmentation which became an integral part of Proto-Indo-European ritual practices was not there from the beginning. Apart from this, there is at least one other theory regarding the Baltic clay figurines that should be further studied. That is the possibility of them being part of a complex gift-giving network of enchainment across the Baltic coasts. I, myself, considered writing my thesis on this subject, but decided to continue with the ancestral trajectory. However, that does not mean that one or the other is less true. Both theories have support in research, and might represent two sides of the same coin. The Comb Ceramic culture operated through such enchainment systems through fragmented slate rings found mainly in Finland and Estonia, many of which were sourced from the Lake Onega region. What is more, is that as previously mentioned, ICP-MA/ES analysis of figurines from Tråsättra show provenance to Gotland and the Åland Islands. One figurine from Glamilders-Svinvallen on Åland resulted in being from an unknown non-Ålandic location (Brorsson *et al*. 2019: 61–62). Additionally, during the period of the Typical/Early Comb Ceramic culture around 3900–3500 BC is when archaeology can trace the oldest type of figurine - the eastern type, which aligns well with the end of the circulation of fragmented ornamental slate rings. The western and younger type (3300–2500 BC) aligns well with the genesis of the Pitted Ware culture. Thus, figurine manufacture and their circulation, can then logically have evolved from the idea of enchainment through the fragmentation and exchange of slate rings; constituting a successor to, and transformation of the tradition. It is possible that the figurines *did* represent ancestors, all the while being amulets of protection on long journeys. Analyzing and discussing the questions and hypotheses of this thesis does certainly prove that such ideas and conceptualizations of non-human agency were interwoven with hunter-gatherer cosmology. Clay figurines as alloforms is at its core a phenomena that has time and again been proven to be a staple of (pre)historical ontologies.

6. Conclusion

The empirical evidence presented in this thesis strongly suggests that the figurines of Tråsättra did represent a stage in Pitted Ware culture mortuary ritual as well as ancestral veneration. Drawing from analogies of similar or related cultures and traditions reveals that practices such as wrapping bodies in animal skin or bark have occurred up until recent times. This suggests a type of cosmology where everything, especially humans and animals are interwoven, dismissing the animal-human dichotomy. Applying plastered death masks over the faces of the dead has existed during the Baltic Neolithic, and examples of death masks have existed in variation through history in several regions, both near and far. The faces of the Tråsättra figurines propose that such masks were used also within Pitted Ware culture communities of eastern Sweden. Further, the absence of mask fragments can be explained by the fact that there is no evidence of firing the masks. Not firing the masks would make the structural integrity of said masks very fragile. The same fact is true in the case of red ochre, with its presence in graves and on figurines strengthening the argument of both wrapped burials and plastered death masks, as all three variables are many times present simultaneously. The Tråsättra figurines are likely a product of cultural- and ritual transmission originating from the Comb Ceramic culture, either as a continuation of an already established tradition, or as a local adaptation of said traditions. Historical- and ethnographical analogies have proven to be an important tool in the understanding of lost cultures and have been integral in filling the gaps regarding how archaeology can understand clay figurine manufacture in the Baltic. In conclusion, this study has established that there are indeed certain variables that strengthen the hypothesis of the Tråsättra figurines as alloforms, and ancestors having returned to the soil.

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